

‘Unity’ over floods proves short-lived as PTI boycotts NDMA briefing

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• Kh Asif terms flood devastation ‘man-made disaster’ • Calls for building small dams, reservoirs, instead of mega projects • Terms local govts essential for disaster management • House to formally begin debate on floods today

By Amir Wasim

ISLAMABAD: The National Assembly’s new session on Monday began with an unusual display of unity as lawmakers from both sides of the aisle expressed solidarity with flood victims, but this bonhomie proved short-lived as the opposition refused to attend a briefing by the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA).

Addressing a news conference outside Parliament House soon after the adjournment of the sitting, PTI leaders, including Barrister Gohar Ali Khan and Asad Qaiser, announced they had decided not to attend the briefing on the orders of incarcerated party leader Imran Khan.

Proceedings continued only for an hour or so before Speaker Ayaz Sadiq cut short the sitting, announc-

ing that the NDMA had arranged a briefing for some 100 MNAs at 6pm and asking members to attend it.

Earlier, the house suspended the normal agenda of the day and decided to initiate a full-fledged debate on the ongoing flood catastrophe that had caused massive devastation in the country’s northern areas and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, besides inundating a vast area of Punjab due to release of water by neighbouring India.

Gandapur conditionally backs Kalabagh Dam’s construction: Page 8

Minister for Parliamentary Affairs Dr Tariq Fazal Chaudhry moved a motion to begin a formal debate on “the situation arising out of the recent devastating floods in

the country”.

‘Man-made disaster’

The highlight of the brief NA sitting was the speech of Defence Minister Khawaja Muhammad Asif, who termed the recent devastation caused by floods “a man-made disaster”.

The minister also called for local government elections in the country, besides stressing the need for building small dams and reservoirs to avert such tragedies in future.

“The catastrophe we are facing [today] cannot be called a natural disaster,” the minister declared.

“We have done value addition by constructing hotels and houses on waterways. We have encroached riverbeds,” he said, adding that this was the third or fourth such disaster

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Quake kills over 800, flattens villages in Afghanistan

- Over 2,800 injured in 6.0-magnitude tremor • Shocks felt in five provinces of Afghanistan, many parts of Pakistan
- Officials fear casualties may rise as rescue efforts hampered by risk of landslides and rock slides after recent rains
- UN chief, PM Shehbaz, President Zardari express condolences; KP govt decides to immediately send medicines

NURGAL: A massive rescue operation was underway in Afghanistan on Monday, after a strong earthquake and multiple aftershocks collapsed homes onto sleeping families in a remote, mountainous region, killing more than 800 people, according to the Taliban authorities.

The 6.0-magnitude earthquake struck just before midnight, rattling buildings from Kabul to Islamabad.

The US Geological Survey (USGS) also recorded at least five aftershocks throughout the night.

Casualties and destruction swept across at least five provinces of Afghanistan, while tremors were also recorded in the two province of Pakistan, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Punjab, besides the federal capital of Islamabad.

Near the epicentre in eastern Afghanistan, around 800 people were killed and 2,800 injured in remote Kunar province alone, chief Taliban government spokesman



AFGHAN men search for their belongings amidst the rubble of a collapsed house in Dara Mazar area of Kunar province.—Reuters

Zabihullah Mujahid said.

Another 12 people were killed and 255 injured in neighbouring Nangarhar province, while 58 people

the rubble of destroyed or severely damaged homes more than 12 hours after the initial earthquake, AFP journalists saw.

The epicentre was about 27km from the city of Jalalabad in Nangarhar province, according to the USGS, which said it struck just eight kilometres below the Earth's surface. Such relatively shallow quakes can cause more damage, especially since the majority of Afghans live in low-rise, mud-brick homes vulnerable to collapse.

Some of the most severely impacted villages in remote Kunar provinces "remain inaccessible due to road blockages", the UN migration agency warned.

Nangarhar and Kunar provinces, which border Pakistan, were also hit by flooding in recent days, authorities said.

Rescuers were battling to reach remote mountainous areas cut off from mobile networks along the bor-

der, where mudbrick homes dotting the slopes collapsed in the quake.

"The area of the earthquake was affected by heavy rain in the last 24-48 hours as well, so the risk of landslides and rock slides is also quite significant — that is why many of the roads are impassable," Kate Carey, an officer at the UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (UNOCHA), told Reuters.

Rescue teams and authorities are trying to dispose of animal carcasses quickly so as to minimise the risk of contamination to water resources, Carey said.

Casualties could rise as rescue teams access more isolated locations, authorities said.

Taliban's defence ministry said at least 40 flight sorties had been carried out on Monday.

A member of the agricultural department in Nurgal said people

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Five army personnel martyred as helicopter crashes in GB

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ISPR says MI-17 copter crash-landed due to technical fault

By Jamil Nagri

GILGIT: A crew of five died on Monday after an army helicopter crashed in Chilas Town, Diamer district of Gilgit-Baltistan, due to a "technical fault", the military's media wing said in a statement.

"On 1 Sep 25, at around 1000 hours, an MI-17 helicopter crash landed near Hudor village, approximately 12 kilometres away from Thakdas Cantonment," the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR) said in the statement. "The helicopter was on routine training flying when it developed a technical fault and crashed."

The ISPR confirmed that all crew members on board embraced martyr-

dom in the incident.

The crew members were identified as Major Atif, who was the pilot in command, Major Faisal, the co-pilot, flight engineer Naib Subedar Maqbool, and crew chiefs Havaladar Jahangir and Naik Amir, according to the ISPR.

President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif expressed deep grief and sorrow over the loss of officers and soldiers in the Army Aviation helicopter crash near Thakdas Cantonment in Gilgit-Baltistan.

In their separate messages, the president and prime minister prayed for the elevation of martyrs' ranks and extended heartfelt condolences to their families, praying for patience and courage for the bereaved.

Gilgit-Baltistan Governor Syed Mehdi Shah also expressed deep sorrow over the tragedy, saying the entire nation was saddened by the martyrdom

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Another case surfaces in KP as polio drive kicks off in Balochistan

By Ikram Junaidi and Saleem Shahid

ISLAMABAD/QUETTA: As a new polio case was found in Tank district of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, taking the total number of cases detected this year to 24, a week-long special anti-polio campaign was launched in 26 of the 36 districts of Balochistan on Monday amid tight security.

The latest polio case involved a 20-month-old girl from Ping union council of Tank district, an official of NIH confirmed.

"This is the 14th polio case from southern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province this year. With this detection, the total number of polio cases found in the country in 2025 reached 24. The break-up of the polio cases is: 16 in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, six in Sindh, and one each in Punjab and Gilgit-Baltistan," the official said.

He said the victim belonged to Bettani tribe, adding that the case belonged to highly security compromised area not accessible for vaccination and no travel history was found.

Meanwhile, a week-long special polio campaign was launched in 26 of the 36 districts in Balochistan amid tight security. Provincial authorities have made strict security arrangements to ensure safety of the polio workers in view of the recent target killing of a supervisor of the Polio Programme in Chaman, a town bordering Afghanistan.

He was targeted by armed men in Roghani area of Chaman while

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Deluge in India may compound Punjab's 'worst-ever flood'

Page 1

- India's releases into Sutlej created 'extraordinary circumstances', officials say
- Chenab, Ravi, and Sutlej surge to 'exceptionally high' levels through central Punjab, threaten province's southern parts
- PDMA warns of urban flooding threat to Lahore, Gujranwala, and Gujrat amid heavy rains
- Over 2.4m people and 600,000 animals displaced; 390 relief camps set up
- 41 deaths reported so far; rescue teams conducting 'largest-ever operation'

By Imran Gabol

LAHORE: Punjab remains in the grip of a worsening flood crisis, as the Chenab, Ravi, and Sutlej rivers surge to "exceptionally high" levels, threatening vast swathes of land, while the Provincial Disaster Management Authority (PDMA) has warned of more torrential rain, which could lead to urban flooding across Lahore, Gujranwala, and Gujrat.

The water level in the Punjab's rivers is expected to rise further after the High Commission of India informed Pakistan of incoming flood-water from the Harike and Ferozepur headworks, according to the Pakistan Commission for Indus Water.

"Harike and Ferozpur along the

Sutlej in India are at high flood level as of 8am on Sept 1, which will affect the water levels in the respective downstream districts," says an advisory released by the PDMA.

Northern India, particularly in the catchment areas of rivers that flow into Pakistan, has been experiencing heavy and continuous rainfall in recent weeks. According to Indian forecasts, the next 36 hours will be critical in Utrakhand, Himachal, Haryana, and Punjab, as there are chances of heavy rainfall in these areas.

As of 1am on Tuesday, the Chenab at Trimmu recorded a massive and steady outflow of 532,498 cusecs, classified as a "very high" flood. A dangerous surge is moving towards Head Trimmu, and water

levels are expected to swell to nearly 700,000 cusecs.

At the same time, the Ravi River is also at a "very high" flood level at Balloki Headworks with 144,675 cusecs, while Sidhnai Headworks is also in a similar state, recording 105,604 cusecs and rising.

The Sutlej River continues to pose a severe threat at Ganda Singh Wala, maintaining an "exceptionally high" flood with steady outflows of 253,068 cusecs. The situation is projected to worsen, with approximately one million cusecs of water expected to converge at Panjnad between Sept 4 and 5.

Bridge collapse cuts off 40 villages from Narowal: Page 2

Heavy rain batters Rawalpindi, Islamabad: Page 4

Looming Glofs: Editorial on Page 6

Good drainage makes good neighbours: Footprints on Page 12

The provincial government, which has termed this its "largest rescue and relief operation," is now shifting its focus south.

A senior government official, speaking on condition of anonymity told *Dawn*, "The water has passed the major central Punjab population centres, but the true test of our infrastructure and preparedness is now at Panjnad and the areas beyond. We are monitoring it on a



PEOPLE displaced by floods settle in a makeshift relief camp on the outskirts of Lahore.—AFP

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TIANJIN: PM Shehbaz Sharif addresses the 25th SCO Heads of States summit, as Russian President Vladimir Putin looks on.—White Star

Pakistan for SCO-led process to resolve South Asian disputes

• Xi calls for creation of new SCO bank to break dependence on dollar • Putin urges shift from ‘Euro-centric’ security model • Tianjin Declaration condemns terror attacks in Pakistan; reaffirms commitment to fight separatism and extremism

By Syed Irfan Raza

ISLAMABAD: Chinese President Xi Jinping on Monday pressed his vision for a new global security and economic order that prioritises the “Global South”, as Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif called on leaders of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) to initiate a structured process to resolve longstanding disputes in South Asia.

“Global governance has reached a new crossroads,” said President Xi, adding that member states “must continue to take a clear stand against hegemonism and power politics, and practise true multilateralism” — a thinly veiled swipe at the US.

Tianjin summit: Editorial on Page 6

The summit brought together more than 20 world leaders, including Russian President Vladimir Putin, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Indian PM Narendra Modi, in the Chinese port city of Tianjin.

In an image designed to convey a mood of solidarity, Putin and Modi were shown holding hands as they walked jovially towards Xi before the summit opened. The three men stood shoulder-to-shoulder, laughing and surrounded by interpreters.

“It’s hard to tell if the scene was choreographed or improvised, but it doesn’t really matter,” wrote Eric Olander, editor-in-chief of The China-Global South Project, a research agency.

Putin, whose country has forged even closer economic and security ties with China amid the fallout from the Ukraine war, said the SCO had revived “genuine multilateralism”, with national currencies increasingly used in mutual settlements.

“This, in turn, lays the political and socio-economic groundwork for the formation of a new system of stability and security in Eurasia,” Putin said.

“This security system, unlike Euro-centric and Euro-Atlantic models, would genuinely consider the interests of a broad range of countries, be truly balanced, and would not allow

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Next two days critical as India releases more water into Sutlej

Page 2

By Afzal Ansari

KASUR: The district administration and rescuers have once again put the flood-hit villages on high alert after India released more water into the Sutlej on Monday.

According to the administration, the next two days are critical and they are making all-out efforts to tackle any untoward situation.

The Sutlej was in exceptionally high flood despite the fact that the water receded to over 100,000 cusecs. Crops at 10 downstream villages were submerged with water as Jalaldinwala embankment was washed away. The villages include Fatohiwala, Chohriwala, Wazirpur, Kujian, Nooriwala,

Kharaipar, Aloanna, Chhabar, Bhadian and Usmanwala whereas the villages on upstream would face a flood wave if Talwar post embankment breaks, said a handout.

It is important to mention here that, in case, the Talwar post dyke breaches, the villages near the city could also be flooded.

The police deputed at Talwar post are not allowing any one to go ahead of the post in the wake of the rising risk of water surge to a dangerous level.

At the Talwar post near the border, the district administration has established its camps, which are in danger as cracks have started appearing in the embankment.

A couple of days back, the administration decided to leave the Talwar post and

establish camps somewhere else, keeping in view the condition of embankment.

On Monday, according to official handout, the water discharge at Ganda Singh headworks was 240,000 cusecs. The Sutlej recently witnessed a water discharge of 385,000 but it reduced significantly in a day as water spread to the villages, washing away several embankments.

The river has been wreaking havoc with its mighty water waves for the last seven days in over 72 villages, the handout further said.

According to the handout, 70,000 people had been evacuated besides 169,000 animals were shifted to safer place in the district so far.

According to Rescue officials, it res-

cued a boat carrying two families and volunteers of a charity organization in the Kothi Fateh Muhammad area of Kanganpur. The rescuers rushed to the spot as the boat riders called for help at 1122. The incident took place due to engine failure.

Separately, two people drowned in the floodwater. Abdul Salam, 30, drowned at village Rajiwal near Mandi Usmanwala while fetching fodder for his cattle. Muhammad Arshad, 18, drowned while bathing in the Ravi at village Sindhu Kalan of Pattoki.

So far, four persons had drowned in the floodwater in Kasur.

On the other hand, water discharge in the Ravi at Head Balloki has reduced to 162,290 from the peak discharge of 225,000 cusecs.

Two LGH staffers suspended after newborn kidnapped

Page 2

By Asif Chaudhry

LAHORE: Two veiled women allegedly kidnapped a newborn boy from the nursery unit of the Lahore General Hospital, highlighting negligence on the part of the institute's management.

The incident left the child's mother in a state of trauma.

Resident of Kahna area, Zeenat Bibi had given birth to a boy two days back and he was placed under medical observation at the nursery unit of the LGH.

On Monday noon, two women entered the nursery unit and took away the newborn.

The surveillance cameras spotted one of the women carrying the

boy and walking down outside the hospital.

The incident sparked anguish among the family members who lashed out at the government hospital's authorities when they allegedly found the director (emergency) and other senior staff absent.

The hospital management suspended a ward attendant, Shakeela Bibi, and staff member Muhammad Usman, while the ward sister incharge and staff nurse were served with show-cause notices besides initiating a formal departmental inquiry.

The administration also engaged the police to launch a kidnap case, arrest the women and recover the baby.

The LGH released a statement on

Monday saying that Postgraduate Medical Institute and Ameeruddin Medical College Principal Prof Farooq Afzal took notice of the kidnap of the newborn and sought a detailed report from the hospital administration.

He stated that those guilty of negligence would not be spared under any circumstances. Prof Afzal added that the police had been engaged for the recovery of the child and the hospital administration was strictly directed to extend complete support to the parents.

The LGH principal said strong security and administrative measures would be enforced to prevent such incidents in the future and to restore the trust of patients and their families in the institution.

Bridge collapse cuts off 40 villages from Narowal

Page 2

By Abid Mahmood

NAROWAL: A local man has started charging people for helping them cross the rainwater drain of Baen on a boat in Narowal. The protective embankment and bridge over the drain at Bheko Chak had broken.

Thousands of people, including children and women, used to go to the towns of Noorkot, Narowal, and other areas every day by crossing the Baen bridge. The collapse of the bridge cut off the land connection of more than 40 villages including Fatehpur Afghan, Baramangah, Malikpur, Jagatpur and Kot Nainan with Noorkot. The residents of these villages used this bridge to go to work, offices, shopping and hospitals. It was used by the students too. In absence of the bridge, the locals are facing difficulties in transportation. Seeing an opportunity of business, Muhammad Munshi, a local man, has made a raft with the help of plastic drums and he is charging Rs30 per person to cross the rainwater drain Baen on the makeshift boat.

Local journalist Muhammad Waseem told *Dawn* that the rainwater drain Baen is 20 to 25 feet deep.

"The rainwater drain is flowing rapidly. Munshi is making the citizens cross the drain without life jackets. The makeshift water boat system is a big threat to the lives of citizens." He said the district administration should build a temporary bridge across the Baen drain with the help of the army to facilitate thousands of people.

The road connecting the villages near to the border near Jassar on the Narowal-Shakargarh road has also been washed away by the flood.

Due to the road collapse, the land connection of the villages of Nangli, Doaba and Fassipur with Narowal



NAROWAL: This man charges Rs30 per person to carry people across the rainwater drain on his makeshift raft. — Dawn

has been cut off. Rescue 1122 water boats are being used to provide transportation facilities to the citizens.

The high level flood in the Ravi River was also washed away at village Ransawal at three places.

The land connection of eight border villages Chandianwali, Dudhewali, Basiwala, Chelewali, Qalandarabad and Ran has been cut off from Narowal. The flood relay created 15 to 20 feet deep holes on the road. The locals have made a temporary system by tying cots with ropes to cross the floodwater.

Muhammad Akbar and Fazal Mahmood told *Dawn* that a resident of our village had died at the District

Headquarters Hospital Narowal during the high-level flood in the Ravi. They said that the body was lying in the hospital for four days due to the flood as the roads were broken.

Narowal Deputy Commissioner Syed Hassan Raza told *Dawn* the district administration was taking steps for the restoration of roads. He claimed that the flood victims were being provided with food, medicine, accommodation, electricity, clean drinking water, fodder for animals and medicine at the flood relief camps. He said the district administration was providing basic facilities to the flood victims on a priority basis by utilising all resources.

‘Urta Lahore’ fest to screen South Asian films

Page 2

LAHORE: Olomopolo Media, in collaboration with known writer and filmmaker Farjad Nabi, is going to hold “Urta Lahore” festival, showcasing the best of South Asian films.

Scheduled to take place from 19th to 21st September, 2025 at Annemarie-Schimmel-Haus - German Cultural Centre, Lahore, the festival will bring together films, talks and interactive sessions that celebrate the region’s shared heritage and vibrant storytelling traditions.

According to the festival organisers, the festival’s title -- Urta Lahore -- is a deliberate choice. they say that around the world, film festivals are often named after their host cities, embedding cultural identity within the place. By placing Lahore at the centre of this initiative, Olomopolo Media reaffirms the city’s historic role as a hub of art, literature, music, and cinema, positioning it as a meeting ground for regional creativity and dialogue.

Speaking about the festival, the curators noted that Urta Lahore seeks to address a critical gap: “There are very few platforms where South Asian films are screened under one roof. Despite our borders and differences, the region is deeply connected by shared histories, languages and artistic sensibilities. Urta Lahore is about creating that space for dialogue and connection.”

They say that the festival comes at a time when there is a growing attention on the Global South, where South Asia’s thriving creative industries and storytelling traditions are increasingly recognised on the world stage. Urta Lahore aims to not only allow South Asia to speak to itself but also to position its cinema as a vital contributor to global cultural conversations, thy add. — **Staff Reporter**

80 Kamalia villages flooded by Ravi

Page 2

TOBA TEK SINGH: A discharge of 200,000 cusecs water in the river Ravi at Kamalia caused havoc on Monday as more than 80 villages were submerged while rural link roads eroded.

People who took shelter on rooftops were later rescued by rescuers. Officials said over 60,000 people were rescued and 890 of them were given first aid. Their 61,999 animals were also evacuated.

The road leading to Chichawatni, Faisalabad and motorway M-3 interchange was submerged near Kalaira Adda at Kamalia.

CM: Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz visited Jhang to oversee the relief work.

She inspected a field hospital near a relief camp and reviewed treatment facilities and availability of medicines being provided to the sick flood affectees.

She visited river Chenab's Jhang city spur where Jhang DC Ali Akbar Bhinder and other officials briefed her about the flood situation and the loss caused to houses and crops.

The DC said each relief camp had been set up at a distance of 500 metres and meal was being provided at all 750 camps without any discrimination. — **Correspondent**

Actor Anwar Ali passes away

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LAHORE: Noted film, TV and stage artiste Anwar Ali passed away after a protracted illness in Lahore on Monday. He was 74.



He is survived by a son, daughter and a widow. He was suffering from kidney and lungs ailment.

The late Ali started his career as a stage artiste from the Open Air Theatre in 1970. He performed at the Lahore Arts Council

theater for about 50 years. Besides, he worked in many popular TV plays such as *Sona Chandi*, *Janjal Pura*, *Andhera Ujala* and *Ababeel*.

His famous theatre plays were *Paisa Bolta Hai*, *Nizam Saqa*, *No lift* and *Jahez*.

Ali gave up theatre in 2017.

His funeral will be held at the Model Town Link Road on Tuesday (today) after his daughter arrives from Germany. The late Ali's friends, colleagues and Lahore Arts Council have expressed deep sorrow and grief at his demise. — **Staff Reporter**

Highest civil award for late AC

Page 2

LAHORE: Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz has approved the highest civil award for Pattoki Assistant Commissioner Furqan Ahmed Khan, who died of a cardiac arrest during flood relief operation.

As per a handout, a grant of Rs10 million will also be given to his heirs.

The late Furqan Ahmed Khan was continuously on flood relief duty for four days despite being a cancer patient. He was busy in rescue and relief operations, and worked continuously to provide food, medicine and other facilities to the flood victims in Pattoki.

The chief minister paid rich tribute to the services of the late Furqan Ahmed, and declared him a true hero who sacrificed his life while helping others in the most difficult situations.

His sense of duty will be remembered forever.



NDMA Chairman Lt Gen Inam Haider Malik briefs parliamentarians on current flood situation.—White Star

‘Unity’ over floods proves short-lived as PTI boycotts NDMA briefing

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in last 12 to 14 years.

Without naming anyone, he said when someone would be obliged to build a housing society on a riverbed, nature would react.

“In KP also, the people had encroached natural flow of rivers. What steps we have taken to remove encroachments on waterways after the country faced similar floods some three years back. He said they would face such tragedies again and again if they did not change their way.

Highlighting damages caused by floods in his home constituency, Mr Asif alleged a “contracting company” had destroyed his city of Sialkot.

“They are influential people and sitting in the Senate,” he said, pointing the finger at Zahir Khan and Bros (ZKB).

It was unfortunate that all big dams had been built by military dictators, while politicians had built hotels on riverbeds, he regretted.

He suggested building hundreds of small dams and reservoirs, instead of waiting for decades to build mega projects, warning that water would become an extremely scarce commodity in the future.

He was of the opinion that they needed to build small dams, which could be completed within a year or two.

“Do not do politics on it. We have political differences, but climate is a national, rather international issue, and it needs a national response,” he said.

LG system

“A comprehensive and robust local government system is needed to serve the masses in the cities, villages and tehsils,” said the minister amid desk-thumping by the members, regretting that presently there were no local body institutions in Punjab and other parts of the country.

The local bodies were essential for disaster management, he said, adding that power must be dispersed to towns, villages, tehsils and districts.

Earlier, Ali Muhammad Khan of the PTI said the federal government should come forward to help KP people. He called for a detailed parliamentary discussion on water issues and the need for building new dams.

“The whole house should think over it as to how we can build dams and reservoirs. There should be no politics on the issue of dams,” the

PTI leader said.

He asked the federal government to complete work on Mohmand Dam project that had been started by the PTI’s government.

He said political parties had failed to build even a single big water reservoir.

PTI Chairman Barrister Gohar Ali Khan drew the attention of the house towards the flood devastations in his Buner constituency, stating that 240 people had died and another 120 were still missing.

He said the party had suspended its political activities in Punjab due to flood situation.

He praised the KP government and the armed forces for their role in the rescue efforts in the province.

He, however, termed the assistance so far provided by the federal government “insufficient”.

PPP’s Naveed Qamar urged collective national action against climate change and environmental mismanagement.

The PPP leader warned that floods could be 22pc more destructive next year, while in the long term, melting glaciers might dry up the Indus and other rivers, turning fertile lands into deserts and threatening centuries-old ecosystems.

Imran urged to seek overseas Pakistanis' help for flood victims

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• PTI parliamentary body says international community showed little interest in flood relief • Endorses boycott of by-polls and resignation from parliamentary committees; daily walkouts planned in NA and Senate to highlight 'lack of democracy' in country

By Ikram Junaidi

ISLAMABAD: Claiming that the international community has not shown interest in supporting Pakistan after floods, the parliamentary committee of the PTI on Monday urged former prime minister Imran Khan to appeal to overseas Pakistanis to donate funds through Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP) government to help flood-hit people in Punjab and KP.

The committee endorsed the decision of Imran Khan to boycott the by-elections and resign from parliamentary committees. It also decided to stage a daily boycott of the National Assembly to send a message to national and international community that the democracy does not exist in the country.

PTI leader Asad Qaiser, while talking to *Dawn*, said that during the meeting, Barrister Gohar Ali

Khan briefed the committee on his meeting with party patron-in-chief Imran Khan, after which the committee endorsed the decision to boycott the by-elections and resign from parliamentary committees.

"However, as international community has hardly shown any interest in supporting the flood victims, the committee decided to urge Imran Khan to appeal to overseas Pakistanis to donate funds for their support," he said.

Replying to a question, Mr Qaiser further said that the overseas Pakistanis would be asked to transfer funds either to KP government or charity organisations of Imran Khan. The funds would be used to support flood victims in both Punjab and KP, he said.

"We fear that the crops will be badly affected due to floods, and next year there will be enormous pressure on the rupee as government will have to import food items

including wheat and rice," he warned. He said that the committee had decided to boycott the parliamentary sessions on a daily basis.

To another question, the PTI leader explaining the decision said that members of parliament would attend the sessions of the Senate and National Assembly and then walk out in protest.

He added that the country lacked the democracy, which was leading to continuous problems and growing security issues.

Rain hits Gandapur meeting

Meanwhile, PTI had arranged a meeting of media persons with KP Chief Minister Ali Amin Gandapur at KP House in Islamabad but heavy rain disrupted the event.

Strong winds dislodged the canopy set up in the lawn, forcing organisers to cancel the meeting. Media persons were later informed that the session could not be held.

Farmers stage hunger strike over unmet demands

Page 3

By Saleem Shahid

QUETTA: Members of Kissan Ittehad Pakistan (KIP) staged a token hunger strike outside the Quetta Press Club on Monday, demanding acceptance of their 15-point charter of demands submitted to the government.

Addressing a press conference, KIP Chairman Khalid Hussain Bathh announced that the strike would continue until the government accepted and implemented their demands related to growers and landowners affected since 2022. Despite repeated requests, he regretted, the government had not taken steps to resolve their issues.

"We are once again presenting our 15-point charter of demands," Mr

Bathh said, adding that a hunger strike camp had been established outside the press club. He warned that if the authorities ignored their demands, the token strike could be converted into a general hunger strike.

He criticised the Balochistan government for failing to provide solar energy systems to growers and zamindars despite promises. Instead, he said, Quetta Electric Supply Company had been disconnecting their power connections.

Mr Bathh demanded that the government allocate funds to growers and zamindars for the solarisation of agricultural tube-wells. He also called for the restoration of Rabi canal tube-well connections in Manjoshori, Nasirabad, and the resumption of power supply in Harnai and Kuchlak.

Militant attacks rise to decade-high in August: PICSS

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In all, 158 terrorists killed in violence and security operations last month

By Our Staff Reporter

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan witnessed an alarming spike in militant violence in August 2025, with militant attacks surging by 74 per cent compared to the previous month, according to data released by the Pakistan Institute for Conflict and Security Studies (PICSS).

The 143 recorded militant attacks made August the deadliest month in over a decade, surpassing all monthly figures since February 2014, the PICSS Militancy Database showed. "The wave of violence left 194 people dead, including 73 security forces personnel, 62 civilians, 58 militants, and one pro-government peace committee member," the report said.

Additionally, 231 others were injured, including 129 security men, 92 civilians, eight militants and two peace committee members. Militants also abducted at least 10 individuals during the month, the institute reported.

In response, security forces escalated operations across the country, killing 100 militants and arresting 31 others. These actions also led to the deaths of three civilians and one security forces member.

Combined casualty toll

When factoring in both militant attacks and security operations, at least 298 people lost their lives in August.

The dead included 158 militants, 74 security forces personnel, 65 civilians and one peace committee member. The number of injured rose to 250, affecting 137 security personnel, 100 civilians, 11 militants and two peace committee members.

The report noted a 100pc increase in the deaths of security forces personnel and a 145pc rise in their injuries compared to July. Militant fatalities rose by 27pc, while civilian deaths climbed 20pc.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

The most significant escalation occur-

red in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, which saw 106 militant attacks, the highest monthly figure in over 10 years.

The tribal districts (erstwhile FATA) experienced 51 of those attacks, a 200pc increase that resulted in 74 deaths.

The fatalities included 41 militants killed in retaliatory fire, 20 security personnel, 12 civilians and one peace committee member. Security forces killed an additional 24 militants in separate operations in the region.

"Mainland KP (settled districts) was similarly hit, with 55 attacks causing 56 deaths, including 26 security personnel, 22 civilians, and 8 militants," the report stated. "At least 81 people were injured, including 53 security forces personnel, 26 civilians, and 2 militants."

Security forces killed 24 militants and arrested 16 others in these areas. Compared to July, the violence in mainland marked a 53pc increase in attacks and a 60pc rise in deaths.

Other regions

Balochistan remained volatile with 28 attacks that resulted in 52 deaths — 23 security personnel, 21 civilians and eight militants. Also, 23 security men and 22 civilians were wounded.

Security forces in the province eliminated 50 militants in operations, the highest number of such deaths since June 2015. Intelligence-led operations also dismantled camps belonging to the BLA and the BLF.

In Islamabad, the Intelligence Bureau thwarted a major plot by the Tehreek-i-Taliban Pakistan, by arresting a would-be suicide bomber and his handler, averting a potential high-profile attack.

Sindh reported six attacks that left eight people dead, including six civilians and two security personnel. Security forces arrested 11 suspected militants in Karachi.

In Punjab, two attacks occurred, including a TTP assault in Dera Ghazi Khan. The incidents resulted in the deaths of one civilian and one attacker. Separately, security forces killed two militants in Mianwali.

In Gilgit-Baltistan, TTP-linked militants attacked the Chilas district, killing two security personnel and injuring one.

Prosecution gets more time to submit case record of Aleema's son

Page 3

By Wajih Ahmed Sheikh

LAHORE: An anti-terrorism court on Monday granted more time to prosecution to produce the case record on a bail petition filed by Shershah Khan, son of Aleema Khan, in the Jinnah House attack.

During the hearing, Aleema Khan and Uzma Khan, sisters of incarcerated PTI founding chairman Imran Khan, were present in the court.

When the matter came up for hearing, the investigating officer sought

more time from the judge to present the case record before the court.

However, the defence counsel argued that the prosecution's failure to produce the record amounted to "delaying tactics".

Shershah, who has been on judicial remand in the May 9 violence case pertaining to the attack on the Jinnah House, the residence of Lahore corps commander, had approached the court for release on post-arrest bail.

After hearing initial arguments from both sides, Judge Manzer Ali Gill allowed the prosecution counsel's request and adjourned the hearing till Tuesday (today).

Cop embraces martyrdom as police thwart attack in KP

By Pazir Gul

NORTH WAZIRISTAN: A police constable embraced martyrdom and another sustained serious injuries on Monday as police officials thwarted an attack, eliminating three terrorists in a deadly confrontation at a police post in Patesi Adda area of Mir Ali Tehsil, a spokesperson for police said.

The spokesperson said attackers opened indiscriminate fire with automatic weapons, but police personnel at the post retaliated, killing three of the terrorists on the spot.

This was the third attack on police personnel in the Bannu division in the last week.

The bodies of the attackers and the injured officer, Inam, were shifted to Mir Ali Hospital. Sources at the hospital said the injured officer was in critical condition.

Following the attack, a large number of security forces and police cordoned off the area and launched an operation to trace facilitators, according to official sources.

Witnesses said the exchange of fire caused panic in the area, leading to the closure of shops and houses. However, they later praised the police for their response.

"The personnel risked their lives and saved the entire area from a major disaster," they said.

The funeral prayers for the martyred police official, Nizamullah, was later offered at Governor Cottage in Miramshah.

It was attended by senior government and military officials, as well as a large number of local residents.

He was presented a guard of honour by a police contingent and laid to rest with official honours.

"Our son sacrificed his life for the sake of the country and we are proud of his martyrdom, but the government should also pay attention to problems of the martyrs' families," family members told the media.

Local tribal elders also demanded that the government ensure the upbringing of the constable's children and provide immediate financial assistance to the family.

Police officials said an investigation is underway.

Man killed in Uthal shooting

GWADAR: A man was gunned down in Uthal town shooting on Monday.

Police said the armed motorcyclist targeted Muhammad Abbas, a resident of Kalat, in the Uthal area.

He sustained multiple gunshot wounds and died on the spot. Police shifted the body to Uthal hospital. The motive for the killing could not be ascertained.

Meanwhile, a man, Samiullah, was found shot dead in the Zndine area of Panjgur. Residents informed administration about the unattended body, which was later shifted to Panjgur district hospital.—Behram Baloch

UN launches migration network in Pakistan

Page 3

• Initiative follows 2016 New York Declaration, aligned with Global Compact for Migration and SDGs • IOM to coordinate, with UN Resident Coordinator Mohamed Yahya as network chair • Pakistan's first Migration Multi-Partner Trust Fund Programme also launched

By Amin Ahmed

ISLAMABAD: The United Nations launched on Monday the Network on Migration in Pakistan to strengthen migration management and governance to facilitate safe, orderly and regular migration.

The establishment of the United Nations Network on Migration (UNNM) marked a significant step towards a unified, collaborative approach to migration governance and responding to the inter-connected challenges of human trafficking and migration smuggling.

The network has been established in Pakistan in pursuance of the 'New York Declaration for Refugees and Migration', unanimously adopted by UN member states in 2016, which created the UNNM. The dec-

laration marked a major commitment to address large movements of people and laid the foundation for two global compacts, including one on safe, orderly and regular migration.

It is aligned with international frameworks, including the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration (GCM), which is the first comprehensive, intergovernmental framework on migration.

The International Organisation for Migration (IOM), as coordinator and secretariat of the UN Network on Migration, plays a central role in the network, alongside the United Nations Resident Coordinator in Pakistan, who will serve as the network's chair. The network will leverage partnerships across the UN system to

promote policy coherence and integrate migration policies into the broader development goals.

Speaking at the launch ceremony, UN Resident Coordinator in Pakistan Mohamed Yahya said the network provides a crucial platform to shift the narrative on migration, amplify a unified voice, and foster the innovation needed to address complex challenges related to mobility and protecting the rights of all people on the move.

Coinciding with the UNNM launch, Pakistan's first Migration Multi-Partner Trust Fund Programme (MMPTF) was also launched. The MMPTF aimed at 'Strengthening Response to Combat Trafficking in Persons' and 'Smuggling of Migrants in Pakistan' is being implemented jointly by the IOM and the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) in collaboration

with the Pakistan government, private sector, and civil society.

The joint programme supports national efforts in migration management and governance and in combatting human trafficking and migrant smuggling with a whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach. The MMPTF was established to support the implementation of GCM and is the only pooled funding mechanism dedicated to migration, open to all states.

In a video message, Head of UN Migration Network Secretariat Jonathan Prentice congratulated Pakistan for continuing to play a significant role in the global effort to help improve migration governance in the world.

The launching ceremony also featured a Pakistani migrant recently returned from an arduous journey to Europe and reinte-

grated back home. "Life makes us move. But journeys, either from our home to new destinations or back to our country, should become easier and more dignified," said Moazzam Ali, who opted for voluntary return to Pakistan from Romania with IOM's support.

A high-level panel discussion titled "Enhancing Whole-of-Government Migration Governance in the Age of Complex Mobility Dynamics and Emerging Global Challenges" was also held. It was moderated by Dr Nasra M. Shah, Professor of Migration and Development at the Lahore School of Economics. Panelists included representatives from the ministries of foreign affairs, interior, overseas Pakistanis and human resource development, the National Commission for Human Rights, IOM, and civil society organisations.

Ministry seeks daily reports on crackdown against Afghan nationals

Page 4

By Mohammad Asghar

RAWALPINDI: The federal government has sought daily reports from law enforcement agencies about the detention of Afghan nationals, except those holding valid visas, for their deportation.

The direction to detain undocumented Afghan nationals and deport them was taken at a meeting held in the Ministry of Interior on Monday.

It was decided that all Afghan nationals holding all kinds of documents, other than valid visas, will be arrested and deported.

In response to the ministry's order, City Police Officer (CPO) Rawalpindi Syed Khalid Hamdani issued an order to the superintendents of police (SPs) Rawal, Potohar and Saddar divisions asking them to direct all SDPOs and SHOs to launch search operations in their respective jurisdictions against illegal Afghan nationals and detain and shift them to the refugees holding centre established at the Government Boys College Dhoke Syedan for their deportation.

The directive said since the government's deadline for voluntary repatriation of illegal Afghan nationals holding Proof of Registration (PoR) cards had expired on August 31, a special meeting was held in the ministry on Monday.

The CPO also directed them to submit a daily report to the Ministry of Interior, the inspector general of police (IGP) and the regional police officer.

Following the government's directive, police teams have been formed to launch searches for illegal foreigners in the district.

BISP beneficiaries to get skills training under new pact

Page 4

By Our Staff Reporter

ISLAMABAD: Benazir Bhutto Shaheed Human Resource Research Development Board (BBSHRRDB) has agreed to train 3,000 Benazir Income Support Programme (BISP) beneficiaries in various trades, with a strong focus on employability and sustainable livelihoods.

For this purpose, BISP and BBSHRRDB signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) here on Monday at BISP Headquarters. This training is under the Benazir Hunarmand Programme, an initiative of the social protection system. The MoU was signed by the Director General, BISP, Ms Romna Gul, and the Secretary Board, BBSHRRDB, Mr Munawar Ali Mithani.

Mr Mithani reaffirmed the Board's commitment to equipping BISP beneficiaries with market-driven skills, ensuring they are better prepared for meaningful employment and entrepreneurship opportunities.

Speaking on the occasion, Senator Rubina Khalid emphasised the importance of the partnership and recalled the words of Shaheed Mohtarma Benazir Bhutto, "Skill is your asset." While we are making lives easier, the greater need is to work on improving lives, she noted.

Heavy rain batters Rawalpindi, Islamabad

Page 4

● Leh Nullah swells to dangerous levels; sirens sounded in Rawalpindi ● Met Office says monsoon system likely to persist till tomorrow ● Rainwater accumulates in G-6, G-7, G-11 sectors and Bhara Kahu in Islamabad

By Aamir Yasin & Kashif Abbasi

RAWALPINDI/ISLAMABAD: Heavy rain lashed the twin cities of Rawalpindi and Islamabad on Monday evening, inundating low-lying areas and causing damage in different parts of the garrison city.

Leh Nullah swelled to 17.5 feet at Gawalmandi Bridge and 19.5 feet at Kattarian Bridge. However, water level receded in the night when the rain stopped.

In the evening, rain and water in Leh Nullah forced the local administration to switch on the sirens of flood warning in the city so that people around Leh Nullah could move to safer places.

The Water and Sanitation Agency (Wasa), Rescue 1122, Civil Defence and health departments called out their officials to deal with any emergency.

Fear and panic ran through the localities adjacent to Leh Nullah and other nullahs in the garrison city with the residents shifting their precious items to the second floors of their houses to avoid damage, especially electricity appliances.

The residents feared that the nullah may burst its banks in case of more rain as the widths of Leh and other nullahs have reduced due to failure of Rawalpindi Development Authority (RDA) and Rawalpindi Metropolitan Corporation (RMC) to clear its banks of encroachments.

The Meteorological Department recorded 46 millimetres of rain at Saidpur, 100mm at Zero Point, 80mm at Golra, 54mm at Bokra in Islamabad and 30mm at Shamsabad, 12mm at Chaklala, 43mm at Pirwadhai, 13mm at Gawalmandi and 64mm at New Kattarian in Rawalpindi. It forecast more rain till Tuesday evening.

A Met official said monsoon currents from Bay of Bengal and Arabian Sea were penetrating into the upper and central parts of the country.



A MAN runs for cover during rain in Rawalpindi's Saddar area on Monday. — Photo by Mohammad Asim

A westerly wave is also affecting upper parts of the country and likely to persist till September 3," he said.

He said that the widespread rainwind/thundershower was likely in Kashmir and northeast Punjab and at scattered places in Islamabad and upper Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

The Met Office warned that torrential rains may cause urban flooding in low lying areas/flash floods in nullahs/streams of Islamabad, Rawalpindi, Narowal, Sialkot, Gujranwala, Gujrat, Mandi Bahauddin, Lahore, Kasur, Okara, Sheikhupura, Hafizabad and adjoining areas. Landslides/mudslides may cause roads closures in hilly areas of KP, Murree, Galliat.

When contacted, Wasa Managing Director Saleem Ashraf said sirens were sounded in localities adjacent to Leh Nullah as water level rose to the pre-alert level of 19.5 feet.

However, he said as the rain stopped in

Islamabad, the water level in Leh Nullah reduced from 19.5 feet to 11.5 feet at Kattarian and from 17.5 feet to 14.5 feet at Gawalmandi by 9pm.

"Less rain occurred in Rawalpindi city but 99mm rain was recorded at Zero Point and G-11 and all the rainwater entered Leh Nullah at Kattarian Bridge which increased the water level in the nullah."

He said as the cleanliness of nullah was completed, the water discharged into Soan River without any hurdle.

He said that all officials were called to deal with any emergency and to drain out rainwater accumulated on roads adjacent to Leh Nullah. District Officer Rescue 1122 Sibghatullah told *Dawn* that there was no report about loss of life during the flood-like situation.

He said Rescue 1122 was on alert till the next 48 hours to deal with any untoward situation, adding teams had been deployed in the city and

along Soan River.

Islamabad

The heavy spell of rain on Monday evening disrupted traffic in various areas of Islamabad as rainwater accumulated on roads, including Bhara Kahu Bypass and Islamabad Expressway.

According to CDA, 99mm of rain was recorded in H-8, 78mm in Golra and 46mm in Saidpur with an overall average of 70mm across the capital city. Rainwater accumulated on roads/streets in G-6, G-7 while some streets in G-7 also faced a flood-like situation. However, after a while rainwater drained out naturally.

However, rainwater accumulated in G-11 Markaz, where motorists faced hardships. Similarly, water remained stagnant in a portion of the deputy commissioner office and in the basement of Nadra office at G-10, which was drained out by emergency and rescue teams.

Similarly, water also accumulated on some roads inside the Diplomatic Enclave, which was drained out within an hour.

A massive rainwater accumulation was reported at Bhara Kahu Chowk on Murree Road, raising question marks about the efficiency of concerned departments. Moreover, Bhara Kahu Bypass was also flooded with rainwater.

Meanwhile, a press release issued by the CDA said on the direction of the interior minister, CDA Chairman Mohammad Ali Randhawa "personally monitored clearance operations across the federal capital, while Deputy Commissioner Irfan Nawaz Memon accompanied him during the field visits." It said immediately after rainfall, CDA and ICT teams launched an operation to drain out water and Diplomatic Enclave and Saidpur Village were completely cleared. Water was also drained from G-11.

It said traffic on all major roads was flowing smoothly.

Court summons police officer on former NA speaker's harassment plea

ISLAMABAD: The Islamabad High Court (IHC) on Monday summoned the investigating officer of Karachi Company police on a petition of former National Assembly Speaker Asad Qaiser against alleged harassment by the Islamabad police despite securing protective bail from the Peshawar High Court.

Justice Khadim Hussain Soomro, while hearing the petition, directed the investigating officer to appear in person at the next date of hearing and remarked that the court would question him directly over the allegations.

Advocate Ayesha Khalid, appearing on behalf of Qaiser, argued that her client was continuously being harassed in violation of his bail protection. The court adjourned the case for one week.

Mr Qaiser has made both the Islamabad police and the Federal Investigation Agency (FIA) respondents in his petition.

Separately, an Anti-Terrorism Court (ATC) Islamabad cancelled the

arrest warrant of former Punjab minister and PTI leader Raja Basharat in the Nove 26 protest case and granted him interim bail.

ATC Judge Abul Hasanat Zulqarnain accepted Basharat's bail against surety bonds worth Rs5,000, issued notices to the parties, and adjourned the hearing till Sept 18.

In another proceeding, ATC Judge Tahir Abbas Sipra issued summons notices to PTI workers in the Octo 4 protest case.

During the hearing, no accused appeared before the court.

The defence lawyers informed the court that the workers, all of whom belong to Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, were unable to travel due to adverse weather conditions.

The court reissued summons notices and adjourned the case. PTI leaders, including Ali Amin Gandapur, Barrister Saif, and Omar Ayub, are also nominated in the case, which was registered at Kohsar police station. — Malik Asad

High achievers of Islamabad schools honoured

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ISLAMABAD: Students of schools under the Federal Directorate of Education (FDE), who got outstanding marks in the recently announced Higher Secondary School Certificate (HSSC) exam, were given reception at the Pakistan National College of Arts (PNCA).

The ceremony was organised by the Ministry of Inter-Provincial Coordination (IPC). As many as 25 students who got over 1000 marks out of 1100 along with their parents attended the ceremony and were given prizes.

Besides others, the ceremony was also attended by National Coordinator on Tourism Sardar Yasir Ilyas, Parliamentary Secretaries Farah Naz and Kiran Dar, FBISE Chairman Dr Ikram Ali Malik and Executive Director of Inter Board of Coordination Commission Dr Ghulam Ali Mallah.

Speaking on the occasion, Secretary IPC Mohyuddin Ahmad Wani said celebrating merit is the institution's top priority. He highlighted the importance of inspiring and incentivising high-achieving students to foster a culture of excellence.

He congratulated the students on their remarkable achievements and appreciated the efforts of teachers, parents and the entire academic community in nurturing talent and promoting academic excellence.

The event served as a platform to recognise and reward the hard work and dedication of students, motivating them to strive for even greater heights in their future endeavors. — Staff Reporter

Rally pays homage to Syed Ali Geelani on 4th death anniversary

Page 4

MUZAFFARABAD: Kashmiri activists, mostly young students, on Monday took to a main thoroughfare in the Azad Jammu and Kashmir (AJK) capital to mark the fourth death anniversary of Syed Ali Geelani, the veteran Kashmiri leader and former chairman of the All Parties Hurriyat Conference (APHC), widely revered by many as the "spiritual soul" of the Kashmir freedom struggle.

Organised by Pasban-i-Hurriyat Jammu and Kashmir (PHJK), an organisation of the post-1989 migrants from Indian occupied Jammu and Kashmir, the "Jehd-i-Musalsal (Unrelenting Struggle) Rally" started from Burhan Wani Chowk and culminated at Ghari Pan Chowk, with participants reaffirming their commitment to Mr Geelani's vision of the reunification of the divided Himalayan region and its merger with Pakistan.

Carrying posters and banners of Mr Geelani, they chanted slogans

including "Pakistan se rishta kya? La Laha Illallah," "We are Pakistanis, Pakistan is ours," and "Geelani, your caravan never stopped, never bowed."

The rally was led by AJK Legislative Assembly Speaker Chaudhry Latif Akbar, PHJK chairman Uzair Ahmed Ghazali, former minister and PML-N leader Syed Murtaza Ali Gillani, APHC representatives, and leaders of the Kashmiri refugee community.

Earlier, speakers, including Mr Akbar, paid glowing tributes to Syed Ali Geelani, describing him as a great soldier of Islam and a true leader of the Kashmiri people who dedicated his entire life to resisting Indian occupation and advocating the right to self-determination.

They recalled his long imprisonments, repeated house arrests, and steadfast refusal to compromise on Kashmir's freedom, reiterating that his slogan "We are Pakistanis, Pakistan is ours" continued to resonate deeply in Kashmiri hearts.

The speakers stressed that the right to self-determination was an inalienable right of the Kashmiri people and that peace in South Asia hinged on a just settlement of the issue through the implementation of United Nations resolutions.

Urging the international community, the UN Security Council, and human rights bodies to hold India accountable for atrocities in occupied Kashmir, the speakers vowed that the blood of martyrs would not go in vain and that the struggle for freedom would continue until victory. — Tariq Naqash

Senate panel nixes bids for CAREC highway project

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Committee shocked by NHA revelation that companies have refused to provide relevant documents, terms bid papers ‘forged’

By Syed Irfan Raza

ISLAMABAD: A Senate committee on Monday invalidated the bids for the Central Asia Regional Economic Cooperation (CAREC) Tranche-III project and called on the National Highway Authority (NHA) to cancel the bids and inform the project financier of its findings regarding the use of “forged” documents to secure all four contracts associated with the Rs170 billion project.

The Senate Standing Committee on Economic Affairs Division also called for the blacklisting of a joint venture (JV) of three firms — M/s Ningxia Communications Construction Co., Ltd NXCC, M/s Dynamic Constructors, and M/s Rustam Associates.

The committee called on the NHA to write to the Asian Development Bank (ADB), the project financier, within two days regarding the firms’ non-compliance and the fraudulent nature of the bids.

It further recommended that the Economic Affairs Division officially notify the ADB that the bids were “technically invalid and were manipulated due to the malafide intentions of NHA officials and the contractors.”

The committee declared the bids null and void, concluding that documents submitted by the auditors were “fraudulent and unverified” and that due process was not followed.

The committee noted that the lead partner, NXCC, had previously been disqualified from two other ADB-funded projects, including CAREC Tranche-II, but was still deemed qualified for Tranche-III.

It also criticised the NHA for awarding the contracts to a company with a history of disqualification and for what it called persistent non-cooperation with the parliamentary investigation.

According to an official statement, issued by the Senate Secretariat, NHA officials told the committee that letters had been sent to all firms, but they had refused to provide the required documents. The committee was shocked to learn that the firms had sent their responses to their auditors instead of directly to the NHA.

“The NHA has failed to submit the required documents to date, despite a commitment made by the CEO, NHA, in the last meeting to provide them within two days,” he added.

After extensive deliberations, the committee concluded that NHA failed to provide the required documents. The auditor of the local firms admitted that they did not have the documents, and both contractors also refused to provide them.

Quake kills over 800

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had rushed to clear blocked roads in the hours after the earthquake, but that badly affected areas were remote and had limited telecoms networks.

"There is a lot of fear and tension... Children and women were screaming. We had never experienced anything like this in our lives," Ijaz Ulhaq Yaad said.

He said that many living in quake-hit villages were among the more than four million Afghan refugees who have returned to the country from Pakistan and Iran after decades. "They wanted to build their homes here."

Condolences pour in

President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif expressed deep condolences, on behalf of the people of Pakistan, to the families who lost their loved ones in the earthquake. The Khyber Pakhtunkhwa government decided to immediately dispatch a consignment of essential medicines to earthquake-stricken regions of Afghanistan, with Chief Minister Ali Amin Gandapur announcing that the provincial government was fully prepared to also deploy medical staff.

—Agencies

Pakistan for SCO-led process

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one country to ensure its own security at the expense of others.”

Xi also called for the creation of a new SCO development bank, in what would be a major step towards the bloc's long-held aspiration of developing an alternative payment system that circumvents the US dollar and the power of its sanctions.

Call for S. Asia dialogue

Addressing the 25th SCO Heads of States Council meeting, PM Shehbaz also made Pakistan's case for normal and stable relations with its neighbours, advocating dialogue over confrontation.

“Pakistan has always believed in the power of multilateralism, dialogue and diplomacy, and shunning unilateralism,” he said, expressing disappointment over the region's extremely disturbing development in the last few months.

Highlighting Pakistan's support for multilateralism, the prime minister said the SCO remained a platform that best represents Pakistan's abiding commitment to regional cooperation and integration.

On regional security, the prime minister reiterated Pakistan's condemnation of terrorism in all its forms, including what he termed “state terrorism,” while recalling the country's immense sacrifices in the fight against extremism.

“We have lost over 90,000 lives and endured economic losses exceeding \$152 billion — a sacrifice unparalleled in history,” he said, adding that foreign elements were involved in recent terror incidents in Balochistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

“We condemn terrorism in all its forms... Those who have long used terrorism for advancing their political interest must know that the world no longer buys this narrative. We had irrefutable evidence of the involvement of some foreign hands



PRIME MINISTER Shehbaz Sharif meets Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on the sidelines of the SCO summit in Tianjin.—Reuters

in the devastating Jaffar Express train hostage incident as well as countless other terrorist attacks against us in Balochistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa,” the PM remarked.

The prime minister also strongly condemned Israel's unjustified aggression against Iran, a fellow SCO member, and called for an immediate end to the bloodshed in Gaza. He reaffirmed Pakistan's support for the two-state solution with pre-1967 borders and Al-Quds Al-Sharif as the capital of Palestine.

He said Pakistan supports a peaceful and stable Afghanistan for the benefit of the entire region, expressing that hope that trilateral cooperation between Pakistan, China and Afghanistan would yield positive results. Addressing the challenge of climate-induced disasters, the prime minister spoke about the devastating floods currently affecting Pakistan due to torrential rains, which have caused massive human and economic losses. He thanked the international community, particularly China, for their solidarity and assistance.

Tianjin Declaration

The summit adopted the Tianjin Declaration, which notably stated: “Member states strongly condemned the terrorist attack in Pahalgam on April 22, 2025.

Member states also strongly condemned the terrorist attacks on Jaffar Express on March 11 and in Khuzdar on May 21, 2025.”

The SCO leaders expressed their “deepest sympathy and condolences” to the families of the dead and the wounded, saying that the perpetrators, organisers and sponsors of such attacks must be brought to justice.

“The member states, while reaffirming their firm commitment to the fight against terrorism, separatism and extremism, stress the inadmissibility of attempts to use terrorist, separatist and extremist groups for mercenary purposes.

They recognise the leading role of sovereign states and their competent authorities in countering terrorist and extremist threats,” the declaration said.

It added that the SCO members were committed to ensuring sustainable international peace and called for joint efforts to counter traditional and new security challenges and threats.

It said that they reaffirmed their determination to continue the joint fight against terrorism, separatism and extremism, as well as against the illicit trafficking of narcotic drugs, psychotropic substances and their precursors, arms smuggling and other forms of transnational organised crime.

Army personnel martyred

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of the five "sons of the soil". "In this hour of sorrow, the families of the martyrs are not alone, the entire nation shares their pain," he said.

GB Chief Minister Haji Gulbar Khan, in a state-

ment, said he had issued directions to impose an emergency at Chilas Hospital and ordered the immediate availability of medical staff.

He also expressed his condolences and paid tribute to the martyred personnel.

Another polio case surfaces in KP

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taking part in creating awareness among the parents along with polio workers before launching the campaign in the area.

“We are providing tight security to our polio workers in all the 26 districts where polio staff was administering polio drops and vaccination,” a senior official told *Dawn*, adding that during the week-long campaign more than 2.18 million children under the age of five will be administered anti-polio drops.

The Emergency Operations Centre (EOC) Balochistan Coordinator Inam-ul-Haq while announcing the campaign programme said that during the drive in the province more than 2.18 million children under the age of five will be administered anti-polio drops.

Calling the campaign, a crucial step in the fight against poliovirus, Mr Haq urged parents to ensure their children receive the vaccine, warning that failure to do so could result in lifelong disability.

“All preparations have been finalised, and vaccination teams have been fully mobilised in both urban and remote areas of the province,” he said.

The campaign was launched in Quetta, Pishin, Qilla Abdullah, Chaman, Barkhan, Dera Bugti, Hub, Jaffarabad, Jhal Magsi, Kalat, Khuzdar, Qilla Saifullah, Loralai, Mastung, Noshki, Nasirabad, Sherani, Sibi, Sohbatpur, Usta Mohammad, Zhob, Musakhail, Chagai, Duki, Lasbela, and Ziarat.

A total of 11,659 teams will take part in the drive, including 9,129 mobile teams, 958 fixed-site teams, and 586 transit teams deployed at bus terminals, railway stations, and other key locations. Mr Haq stressed that the success of the campaign depends heavily on the community support. He appealed to civil society members, teachers and religious leaders to help raise awareness about polio among the masses and encourage families to get their children vaccinated.

Alongside the polio campaign, he also reminded parents of the importance of routine immunisation, which protects children against 12 vaccine-preventable diseases such as measles, tuberculosis, hepatitis B, and diphtheria.

He urged families to visit their nearest health centers to ensure their children receive all scheduled vaccines on time.

Balochistan govt plans to make solar panels in Hub

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QUETTA: A meeting of Balochistan Investment Board and Trade on Monday discussed setting up of solar panel plants in Lasbela Industrial Estate at Hub to start manufacturing of solar panel sheets in the province.

The meeting, presided over by the chairman of the board, Mr Bilal Khan Kakar, discussed in detail the proposed plan of local manufacturing of solar panel sheets by establishing solar plants in Hub industrial area.

The meeting also discussed utilisation of Low BTU gas in Sui and Kalat.

The plan for setting up solar panel plants in Hub Industrial Estate will be

implemented with the approval of the provincial government. The plan would be submitted to the government soon after preparing its initial report.

At the meeting, Mr Bilal said that the Balochistan government is committed to promoting sustainable energy projects under investment-friendly policies.

He said that Lasbela Industrial Estates Development Authority's (LIEDA) more than 250 active industrial units provide investors with a significant competitive advantage, which can be further enhanced under the Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model.—Saleem Shahid

Tianjin Summit

THE SCO's two-day summit, which concluded in the Chinese city of Tianjin on Monday, offered a glimpse into a more multilateral world; where sovereign nations can come together as equals, breaking away from the West-led, Eurocentric model that has prevailed since the end of World War II, and which is currently under severe strain. It also offered a forum where bilateral disputes and diverging viewpoints can be addressed and accommodated through a multilateral lens. For example, the Tianjin Declaration condemned the terrorist attacks targeting the Jaffar Express and in Khuzdar, along with the Pahalgam episode, signalling that condemnation of militancy should not be selective, and terrorism in all its forms should be shunned. This is also a validation of Pakistan's narrative, as this country has been denouncing the Pahalgam attack from the beginning, while also calling for hostile foreign actors to desist from supporting terrorist violence within its borders. It also suggests that certain states' efforts to isolate Pakistan internationally have failed.

Additionally, the declaration called for an immediate ceasefire in Gaza while highlighting the "catastrophic humanitarian situation" in the besieged Strip and denouncing the US-Israel aggression against Iran. The fact is that any emerging multilateral order must be based on justice and international law. All those who violate these basic principles must be censured, unlike the present system, where perceived enemies face the full force of the law, as well as military aggression, while friends literally get away with murder. Israel's ongoing genocide in the occupied territories is the most glaring example of this hypocrisy.

The West, primarily the US and its European/Nato allies, are highly suspicious of groupings such as the SCO and BRICS, mainly because they challenge their entrenched hegemony on world affairs. Moreover, Western states are loath to see their 'foes' such as Vladimir Putin and Masoud Pezeshkian being accorded full protocol. They should remember that many of them treat Benjamin Netanyahu with even more reverence despite his criminal acts. Russia and China, which are currently leading the push towards a more multilateral global order, may not be perfect examples to emulate. But unlike the West, they are seen to support a more equitable world system, where the Global South has a voice. Countries like Pakistan must take full advantage of the emerging regional and global formations. However, one set of global hegemonies must not be replaced by another. Rather, a just new order is required where the social, economic and political rights of all states are respected. The future need not be one of confrontation between SCO/BRICS and the Western bloc, but of cooperation, where the path to progress has no strings attached.

Looming Gage Glofs

THE Met Office's latest high-priority alert for glacial lake outburst floods in Gilgit-Baltistan ought to jolt the authorities into action. Rising temperatures, well above normal, are accelerating glacier melt, threatening sudden deluges in valleys including Darkut, Hisper, Hopar, Ghundus and Gulkin. For GB's residents, this is more than a forecast: it is a frightening prospect of yet more loss. In recent weeks, a glacier burst in Ghizer district displaced over 3,000 people, destroyed more than 200 houses, and severed critical road links. Entire villages had to flee, saved only by the quick thinking of a shepherd who raised the alarm in time. In Danyor, seven volunteers were buried alive while repairing water channels damaged by earlier floods. Such events have shown that when disaster strikes, ordinary citizens are the first responders, while the state arrives late, if at all. Pakistan has not lacked resources or projects. Donor-backed initiatives such as Glof-II promised early warning systems, resilient infrastructure and community preparedness. Yet, the same mistakes are made every year. Relief is delayed, coordination between agencies is weak, roads and bridges are rebuilt only to collapse with the next flood and local knowledge is sidelined. After each tragedy, officials offer condolences and compensation cheques, but lasting preparedness remains elusive.

This time must be different. Authorities in GB cannot wait for rivers to burst their banks before acting. Evacuation plans should be in place, safe shelters identified and relief supplies stockpiled. Search-and-rescue teams must also be pre-deployed in vulnerable valleys, ready to move immediately rather than hours later. Communities must be kept informed with timely, clear warnings, not vague advisories. Volunteers need proper training and protective equipment, not reliance on their bravery alone. Infrastructure must be reinforced, not patched up with stopgap fixes. Above all, accountability is essential: funds earmarked for disaster management must be transparently audited and publicly disclosed, so citizens can see whether promises are matched by actual delivery. GB's glaciers will continue to melt given our ever-warming climate. But while Glofs are inevitable, repeated human failures are not. The people of GB deserve more than sympathy after the fact; they deserve a government that takes their peril seriously. If this warning too is allowed to pass without action, it will not be nature alone that is to blame for the devastation to come.

Society scrutiny

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THE ongoing floods, which have swept away homes and livelihoods across vast swathes of the country, have once again highlighted the perils of unchecked development. Many families have seen their life savings buried under mud and debris simply because housing societies were allowed to spring up in places where they should never have been allowed to build. The question is not only why their construction was permitted, but also why a nexus between the land mafia and regulators seems to thrive. The rot runs very deep. Pakistan's real estate sector has for years functioned with minimal regulatory or legal oversight, leaving even those who purchase land in ostensibly safe areas vulnerable to financial ruin. Unscrupulous developers routinely defraud citizens, while regulators, whose primary task is to protect the public, often look the other way or feign ignorance.

Take the federal capital, for instance. A recent report has revealed that the Capital Development Authority has known since February 2024 that housing scheme sponsors have not been sharing allotment records through a digital platform, as it had mandated the previous year. This requirement was meant to ensure that the CDA could verify transfer letters and restrict approvals to plots within CDA-approved plans. Yet, despite recognising the risks to buyers, the authority has failed to act. The result has been fraudulent practices, such as over-invoicing and the 'sale' of a single property to multiple buyers, even in the country's most regulated city. If this is the situation in Islamabad, one can only imagine the vulnerabilities faced elsewhere. It is clear that the state has abdicated its duty to protect citizens and their property. Until regulators are compelled to enforce their own rules, and until illegal and fraudulent practices are met with real consequences, the public remains exposed to exploitation. The authorities can no longer afford to ignore an industry that affects millions of families. Strict action is needed.



Past as the future

Whether the empowerment of the people is really the objective is the question.

MORE provinces or empowered local governments? The debate has been sparked, it seems. And it wasn't just due to forwarded-as-received WhatsApp posts, which 'announced' multiple, smaller provinces but also the research presented by media owners-turned-public intellectuals, who are so convinced of the need for this reform that they are now trying to shape opinion at large.

The government and its allies profess ignorance and deny that any such move is in the offing. But the rest of us know better and are taking these 'mazameen' (inspiration) from 'ghaib' (unknown) rather seriously. After all, unlike the government, the rest are openly aware of the importance of the unknown. As a result, the debate rages on.

More provinces are needed, we are told. India has been carving out states whenever needed. It helps improve governance because the 'seat' of the government is closer to the people; for instance, the people of south Punjab would find, say, Multan more accessible than Lahore. It would also ensure cities such as Karachi get the resources and attention they deserve. And, aside from these other benefits, some argue, it would also weaken political dynasties that control entire provinces.

But not everyone is convinced. In fact, there has been commentary and discussions highlighting how cumbersome and time-consuming the process of establishing new provinces could be. For instance, every new province requires a two-thirds majority in the relevant assembly and even if this is managed, it would be followed by a drawn-out process of administrative measures (such as the drawing up of new boundaries) and the setting up of governments in multiple parts of the country. It has been asked if this would not add to the existing polarisation. Local government has been offered as a solution — an alternative that has, perhaps, more supporters than the idea of new provinces.

These proposals have generated an interest

because of the acknowledgment that the current political system is not working and — whether in democratic set-up or a hybrid dispensation — all political parties have struggled with governance and implementation of the needed reform. This is the silent consensus regardless of party affiliation — other than the party heads who have turned parties and provinces into fiefdoms and have no interest in any change. Indeed, the 18th Amendment has ensured the older, mainstream parties now only have regional ambitions, ie, dominating the provinces rather than trying to increase their cross-country appeal. There is a direct link between the 18th Amendment and the increasing focus of the PPP in Sindh and the PML-N in Punjab.

But this is a digression. Most others realise the need for change in the political set-up, assuming, or rather hoping, that this will lead to badly needed reform, especially in the economic sphere, and an improvement in governance.

However, the various discussions on the topic should not ignore the larger, political context in which these solutions are conjured up. And this larger context is one in which political parties are hampered, civilian space is limited (if not non-existent) and very unsubtle efforts are being made to argue that parliamentary politics and parties have failed to deliver.

In the past, whenever we have had similar moments, the devolution of power has always been offered as the magical solution. This age-old formula is supposed to ease the people's misery, empower them and rid them of corrupt politicians. But whether the empowerment of the people is really the objective is the question because it is offered at moments when the centralisation of power is also at play. It appears as if the present times may prove to be no different.

But this is not all. The second issue is that such efforts rarely prove permanent. Just consider Pervez Musharraf's local government system. By the time general elections were held in 2002 and

'parliamentary democracy' restored, the politicians at the provincial and national level began to slowly reverse or weaken the local government systems. Come 2008, and the system was more or less wrapped up.

Once the 18th Amendment was passed, power was concentrated at the provincial level, and the local governments were left to the mercy of each government (the amendment conveniently allowed each provincial assembly to pass its own local government act and decide how much powers to devolve). Initially, even this legislation was delayed till pressure from the courts forced the hand of the provincial governments. And the parties running the provinces made sure they passed legislation that led to weak and ineffective local governments. Perhaps one can say that the local governments enjoyed about as much power as the present federal government does. Even the PTI, which introduced a relatively stronger local government in KP, progressively weakened them as time went on.

Hence, it might not be a waste of time to ask how long-lasting any such move will be. Partly because half the challenge in Pakistan is the back and forth between different experiments as elites try to strengthen themselves against their rivals. This tug of war means there is little stability in terms of the path ahead.

Perhaps what we need additionally at the moment is not just a discussion on the political reform needed but also a debate about what could create a consensus on the need for more devolution of power. What would push political parties to not just acknowledge but also accept the need for local governments or more provinces? Without this kind of a consensus, any such effort to devolve power will not be easy and if pushed through coercion, it will last as long as its creators enjoy power. Beyond that moment, anything is possible. Such formulas bring neither stability nor progress. ■

The writer is a journalist.



To dump West, embrace BRICS

BY habit, the choreographed Indian crowd began to chant "Modi Modi" at an event for the Indian prime minister's two-day visit to China. The Chinese hosts, on the other hand, greeted him with a knowledgeable display of Indian classical music, something Indians would struggle to reciprocate if it ever came to that. There's a trade deficit, and there's evidently a cultural deficit too. Three sari-clad Chinese women performed *Vande Mataram*, an Indian nationalist favourite, in Rag Desh on the sitar and santoor as the third kept rhythm on the tabla. But there are more urgent reasons than China's showcasing its soft power to woo a pro-America Narendra Modi, on an emotional rebound, to make a compelling case for BRICS. Dumping the Western capitalist model that has spawned wars and exploitative sanctions is a need that preceded the dismantling of the USSR.

Western perfidy targets friend and foe alike if business interests clash. The malaise is older than Donald Trump. Among my early observations in this regard was the West's betrayal of Kuwait before Saddam Hussein was hustled into completing the job. The story goes back to the 1987 stock market crash when the Thatcher government was in the process of selling its remaining 31.5 per cent stake in BP. The crash threatened to derail this massive sale, potentially costing the treasury billions. The Kuwait Investment Office, the investment arm of the Kuwaiti sovereign wealth fund, stepped in to bail out the UK. It began purchasing BP shares on the open market. Initially, the UK government was pleased. The KIO's buying provided crucial support to the BP share price, helping to ensure the success of the government's own share sale. In a short time, the KIO had acquired a 21.6pc stake in BP, making it by far the largest shareholder. The UK government's stake was now zero.

Suddenly, Margaret Thatcher's government was uncomfortable with a controlling stake being held by a foreign government, even a friendly one. A 21.6pc stake gave Kuwait significant power and the idea of a major British icon falling under effective control of an OPEC member state was politically toxic, even for a pro-market government like Thatcher's.

Thatcher formally instructed the KIO to reduce its holding. They were ordered to sell

down their stake to no more than 9.9pc. The government made it clear that if Kuwait did not comply voluntarily, it would use its legal and regulatory powers to force the issue, potentially damaging diplomatic relations and Kuwait's other investments in the UK. Kuwait, a close ally that relied on Western protection, ultimately complied to maintain good relations.

What happened with Pakistan's prestigious BCCI bank was not entirely dissimilar. The CIA acknowledged using the major international bank as a conduit to secretly fund the Afghan mujahideen. The job done, the bank turned into an object of envy for the West. To quote Shakespeare, the West was mocking the

India has 800m on food dole, signalling the contradiction between its right-wing government shored up by big money and people's priorities.

very meat it had fed upon. BCCI was not the cleanest bank and lent itself to narratives of corruption, fraud, drug peddling and money laundering. But here's the rub. Major Western banks have paid billions in penalties for knowingly laundering drug money. They never had to shut down.

A US Senate investigation found that a Western bank had systematically laundered at least \$881 million for Mexican and Colombian drug cartels over years. The bank moved bulk cash from its Mexican subsidiary to the US, bypassing money laundering controls. The concerned bank avoided criminal prosecution and paid a \$1.9bn fine, a sum widely criticised as a 'slap on the wrist' given the scale of the crimes and the bank's profits. In the 2008 financial crisis and mortgage-backed securities fraud, multiple American banks paid tens of billions in penalties for packaging and selling toxic mortgage-backed securities they knew were likely

to fail, while simultaneously betting against them. This fraud triggered the global financial crisis. But they were politically protected unlike Pakistan's bank. The BCCI had dared to challenge Western monopoly and suffered for it. BCCI was the first truly major global bank from the developing world. Its rapid growth, aggressive strategy, and ability to woo clients away from traditional Western banks caused resentment and unease. This meant it had fewer powerful friends in the financial capitals of London and New York to defend it when trouble started.

In a similar vein, the ongoing targeting of Huawei and other prominent Chinese tech firms like ZTE, TikTok and Xiaomi is indeed a central piece of this pattern. Adding Huawei to the analysis of the Indian situation reveals a spectrum of tactics used by Western powers, primarily the US, when dealing with rising non-Western competitors.

The botched efforts that have been made to dismantle states like Russia, Venezuela and Iran to lay them open to Western carpetbaggers are well known. Much of the Middle East from Libya to Yemen has suffered for that and more.

Capitalism is driven by private profit and has congenital aversion to social welfare. India has 800m on food dole, signalling the contradiction between its right-wing government shored up by big money and people's priorities.

Gautam Adani and Mukesh Ambani, two leading Indian tycoons, are in trouble with the US, one for alleged bribery to woo American investors, the other for defying Donald Trump's fiat against importing Russian oil. The two led the pack of Gujarati businessmen in 2013 to nominate Modi as their prime ministerial candidate for the 2014 elections. Modi thanked them and did what he does best.

He saw Uttar Pradesh burst into a communal frenzy on election eve to give himself an easy ride to power. The Adani-Ambani crony conundrums are serious issues and Indians should address them with political power rather than leaving them open to Western manipulation. BRICS is just the platform to gear up for the fight, preferably with fewer Modi chants. ■

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Impending crises

WE may be among the most crisis-prone nations globally. In this writer's view, we have faced nearly 30 crises since 1990 or one every 14 months on average. This includes political crises when the ruling set-up or its head were removed in contentious circumstances (seven); economic crunches that led us to the IMF (eight); natural and health-related calamities like earthquakes, floods and Covid-19 (four); internal or external security challenges (five) and crises due to street unrest (five).

This sorry status arises from the state's predatory, security and autocratic bent. The economic crises arise as our predatory rulers induce fickle growth via high twin deficits. The external security crises reflect the hold of hawks on both sides of our eastern border. The internal challenges come from the gripes of excluded ethnicities or our tolerance in the past of violent groups to gain a regional security edge. The political crises and street unrests relate mainly to establishment feuds with politicians. Natural crises cause excessive harm as our rulers eschew disaster management. Economic progress requires peace and economic stability, which need political stability, which, in turn, requires political legitimacy. So, a prolonged loss of political legitimacy lies at the root of all our crises.

The longest crisis-free phase after 1990 was 2001-2005 when a military-led set-up induced questionable stability via fickle US aid and repression. But it only delayed and magnified the inevitable crises that erupted during our first polycrisis from 2005-08. We witnessed the 2005 earthquake, the start of Baloch and TTP violence, Benazir Bhutto's death and street unrest, and the 2007-08 economic crisis the set-up caused. They led to its fall despite its macho aura of invincibility and debatable claims of progress.

The Baloch and TTP-linked crises have raged on since then. The frequency of crises has gone up. The PPP inherited the 2007-08 economic crisis that was boosted by the 2008 global recession. It witnessed the mega floods of 2010 and the removal of its prime minister in 2012. Its government caused an economic crisis in 2013. The PML-N inherited the economic crisis, faced the PTI dharna in 2014, lost its prime minister in 2017 to court decisions, and caused an economic crisis itself in 2018. The PTI inherited the problems, faced Covid-19 in 2020, caused an economic crisis in 2021 and saw its prime minister removed through a no-trust vote in 2022. This started our second polycrisis with floods in 2022, mismanaged economic crisis, PTI protests till 2024, spikes in militant violence and war with India in 2025.

Given the internal boost from the war, resurgent ties with the US and (fickle) economic stability, this hybrid set-up is claiming stability and invincibility. But Pakistan is the humbling ground of many a haughty regime that exuded sham invincibility. In trying to escape the strong pull of the root causes of crises, it faces the same insoluble puzzle as past set-ups — achieving elusive stability. Repression may only delay the inevitable and cause a bigger polycrisis.

Flawed policies are already fomenting future trouble. The failure to fix our perennial external deficits may cause an economic crisis as growth picks up. Given the government's inability to fix the deeper causes of insecurity, our three external and local security foes may jointly try to inflict more violence. If civilians are supposed to forego democratic freedoms in order to fortify the 'same page', it may, instead, lead to cracks and divisions in the regime, ie, establishment-civilian, the PPP-PML-N, intra-

Flawed policies are fomenting future trouble.

PML-N, and cause a political crisis. Greater autocracy may spark national anger against oppressive policies, which may ignite Arab Spring-type protests. Natural crises remain a wildcard given the neglect of

disaster control.

So, despite the rulers' incumbency plans, based on dubious assumptions of durable stability, we may be an external shock away from an economic crisis, a terrorist attack away from war, a spark away from street unrest, a civilian refusal away from a political crisis and a big monsoon season away from a natural crisis. Such events may quickly negate the desperate attempts to exude an aura of invincibility that set-ups with low legitimacy need badly and that cause their fall.

A crisis-weary nation can see an end to the recurrent crises only through political legitimacy based on fair polls and civilian sway. Otherwise, with external, economic, demographic, security and natural threats set to increase in the coming decades, we may become even more crisis-prone. ■

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Manmade disaster

INTENSE rainfall is not uncommon in our plains and mountains. Rainfall exceeding 200mm has occurred several times in every province of Pakistan. 'Climate change', 'cloudburst' and 'urban flooding' are only recent additions to our media lexicon. Flood disasters, landslides, furious hill torrent flows and terrible droughts have been causing loss of life and damage to property, crops and infrastructure for decades. However, a hysterical media and a clumsy social media have sparked paranoia. The cacophony they have raised has kept us from discussing the underlying causes of these disasters. Regurgitating climate change and cloudburst rhetoric will not prevent catastrophic events.

Three human-induced factors, in particular, have made the hydro-climatic events more intense. Rampant deforestation that has denuded mountains of their green cover, increased obstructions on waterways that impede natural flows and climate-insensitive infrastructure are the root cause of the havoc. August's second half proved calamitous for the provinces and Gilgit-Baltistan. In one week, the number of casualties dwarfed the total toll of the previous five weeks.

The disaster in these areas did not result from a few abnormal downpours or landslides. Havoc was being nurtured in the belly of the mountains for decades. Malakand, famous for its dense forests, is now infamous for its menacing pace of illegal deforestation. The Swat valley has several areas where deforestation takes place. The massive logging in Bahrain, Madyan, Kalam, Matta, Malam Jabba, Gabin Jabba and other areas is no secret. The woodlots policy has been blatantly abused in these areas. A news report last year revealed that up to 15 to 20 timber-loaded trucks were being transported to Punjab every day. Forests are a natural glue that protect mountains from fragmentation and abrasion. As forest cover thins out, the mountains are exposed to gushing flows. When natural barriers are removed, these flows attain a ferocious velocity that erodes big boulders and rocks.

Boulders roll down these denuded hills into roaring streams that rise from high altitudes and plummet sharply to thousands of metres. Buner, which endured terrible devastation, inclines upwards from 360 metres in the south to reach a maximum height of 2,910m at the Dosara Peak in the north. Given such drastic variations in altitude, a bout of intense rainfall can generate torrents of unimaginable potency. Forests in Swat were ruthlessly devoured during 2007 to 2009 when the Taliban seized the territory.

Kashmir tells a similar story. A news

report last month mentioned that floods in the Neelum Valley brought a huge bounty of illegally cut timber to Nauseri Dam near Muzaffarabad. Clandestine deforestation in the area intensified the floods. Research based on variations in forest cover maps in 2023 concluded that GB lost over 1,700 square kilometres of forest cover in two decades. It disclosed that Chilas subdivision witnessed the highest rate of deforestation between 2000 and 2010 when over 8,600 acres of forest vanished from the map. Darel/Tangir and Astore ranked second and third in this race to the bottom. These areas felt the impact of the recent devastation.

The upper Indus Basin is dotted with more than 3,000 glacial lakes that burst due to heavy rains and generated lethal flows. GB's population has nearly doubled since 1998. New settlements have been created. Careless tourism has further tested the fragility of the ecosystem. The burgeoning population, especially the poor, tend to occupy empty land in

The disaster was not caused by a few abnormal showers.

the mountains, the river plains, forests and deserts everywhere in the country, as witnessed in the floodplains of Punjab and Sindh, where large numbers of people were displaced from *katcha* areas due to the devastating floods

in the last week of August. As admitted by Defence Minister Khawaja Asif, Sialkot was submerged due to encroachments hindering the waterways. The dry beds of the Sutlej, Ravi and Chenab rivers were massively encroached upon and hence witnessed damage and displacement when the floods roared in after four decades.

Encroachments have clogged the waterways in the urban and rural areas. Infrastructure has been developed without giving any thought to the impact of the raging climatic events. From the mountain peaks to the coastline, a comprehensive climate audit and a grand overhaul of the ecosystem has become a necessity.

Recurring disasters in the mountains of Swat and GB and the floodplains of southern Punjab and Sindh need to be scrutinised from a different angle. Putting together the pieces of the jigsaw puzzle, a sad picture reveals itself: disasters are triggered more by frequent and sustained bursts of misgovernance than cloudbursts. ■

Bhutto-Khalid talks

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TAIF: Prime Minister Zulfikar Ali Bhutto here today [Sept 1] held ... talks with King Khalid and Crown Prince Fahd, "in an atmosphere of fraternal bonds and mutual understanding" that characterises Pak-Saudi ties, a Pakistan delegation spokesman said. He said the two leaders reviewed the situation in the region with special references to developments in the Middle East and those occurring lately in South Asia. The spokesman said ... relations between the two countries were also reviewed, including various stages of the growth of cordiality and warmth that has marked their ties.

[Meanwhile, as reported by news agencies from Washington,] US President Gerald Ford declared today [Sept 1] that the interim peace agreement initialled by Egypt and Israel was fair and balanced, reduced the risk of war in the area and provided fresh hope for progress towards a final peace. In a statement issued as he was making calls to Israeli Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin and Egyptian President Anwar Sadat, Mr Ford said he was deeply gratified by the accord and "proud of America's contribution..." ...[M]r Ford said that the accord had reduced the danger of military and economic warfare.

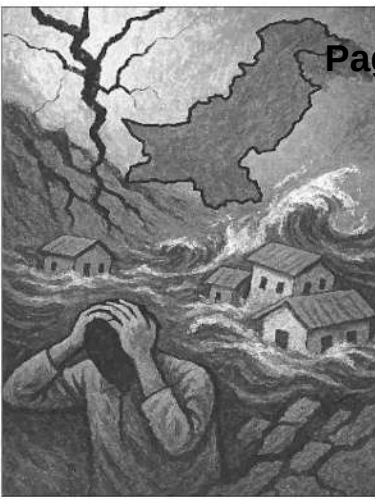
F.O. Aziz out on bail

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KARACHI: Flying Officer M.A. Aziz of the RPAF was released on bail by the Karachi City Magistrate, Mr A.R. Qazi, on Friday [Sept 1]. The bail was granted by the magistrate after four prosecution witnesses had been examined at the resumed hearing of the case. The witnesses included two girls who were in the party which was hit by an aeroplane, allegedly flown by the accused, killing two girls at Clifton beach on June 9.

A nurse of Jinnah Central Hospital and Dr Mistry, to whose clinic the injured girls were removed after the accident, were the other two witnesses. The prosecution counsel, Mir Inam Ullah, did not object to the accused being released on bail. He stated that on perusal of the evidence so far produced in the court, he had come to the conclusion that Section 302 PPO (murder) was not applicable. — Staff correspondent

[Meanwhile, according to news agencies from Bannu,] Reliable information from Kabul reveals that those leaders of the Democratic Party who were suspected of disloyalty to the throne and were arrested ... are now to be tried by court to avoid the censure of the ... public who are very resentful about the arrests.



Response to disaster has to be efficient

TIME and again, the world has warned us that climate change is having a significantly negative impact on the country, and that things are bound to go from bad to worse, but, unfortunately, we have continued to ignore all such warnings.

Despite repeated alerts, the government has failed to make adequate arrangements to face natural disasters. The recent monsoon season has once again exposed our vulnerabilities, especially in Punjab, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP), and Gilgit-Baltistan (GB), where devastating rains, floods and landslides have already claimed over 200 lives, and the monsoon is far from over yet.

This is a complete failure of the government at both national and provincial levels. Pakistan is a disaster-prone country, frequently affected by floods, earthquakes, droughts, and climate-induced emergencies. Managing these crises requires a coordinated response across different tiers of governance.

The responsibility primarily lies with three key institutions: the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA), the Provincial Disaster Management Authorities (PDMAs), and the District Disaster Management Authorities (DDMAs). The NDMA is responsible for setting national policies, coordinating major disaster responses, and liaising with international agencies. On the other hand, the PDMAs implement strategies and manage resources at the provincial level. The DDMAs, however, happen to be the most crucial tier, as they are the first responders at the local level — tasked with preparedness, evacuation, relief and rehabilitation.

Despite their importance, the DDMAs often turn out to be the weakest link.

They face chronic underfunding, seriously lack trained personnel, and have minimal access to modern equipment and early warning systems. They are typically limited to executing orders from above, rather than having the capacity to lead local initiatives.

They do not even have full-time staff and offices. They also lack machinery, supporting staff and networking with the local councils and elected representatives. There are no early warning systems installed at the local tier.

This approach undermines effective disaster response. In many cases, delays, confusion and poor coordination stem from the neglect and disempowerment of local authorities. A resilient disaster management system must start at the grassroots level.

One solution is to link the DDMAs with union councils (UCs). Unfortunately, despite the 18th Constitutional Amendment mandating regular local bodies elections, transfer of financial and management powers, the provinces of KP, Punjab and Balochistan have not held these elections. Only Sindh has conducted elections consistently, and has some active local bodies. Besides, no Provincial Finance Commission, mandatory after the 18th Amendment, has been announced.

Our neighbouring countries, like Bangladesh and India, as well as many disaster-prone countries in other regions have demonstrated how empowering local councils, and transferring resources and authority to them enhances disaster preparedness and response mechanism. In Pakistan, however, local governments have remained neglected.

The federal and provincial governments should seriously consider empowering the local government system and strengthening the DDMAs. Working together with UC representatives, the DDMAs must be empowered to prepare evacuation and disaster response plans for every village and locality.

Pakistan must build resilient institutions, engage civil society, and prepare communities to save lives and livelihoods.

Aijaz Ali Khuwaja
Karachi

False freedom

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GENDER discrimination is not a conflict between men and women, it is a system that forges two cages out of the same iron. One is painted obedience, where women are told to shrink, stay silent, and accept dependency. The other is painted dominance, where men are told to harden, provide endlessly, and never betray emotion. Different labels, same chains. And both corrode the soul.

Its poison runs deep. Women are barred from earning, while men are burdened with carrying everything alone. Women who dare to speak are branded rebellious, while men who dare to soften are mocked as weak.

Even harassment is silenced at both ends:



women fear not being believed, men fear not being taken seriously. What we call tradition is, in truth, fear hidden behind the mask of respectability.

Things being what they are, gender equality cannot be framed as generosity towards women alone; it is liberation for men as well. A society that forces one half into silence, and the other into exhaustion is not surviving, it is decaying. In either case, it is not thriving.

The 'war' was never across gender lines. The war is between us, the victims, and the system that convinces us that cages are natural. And, here lies the truth we prefer to avoid: the cages are not divine, not destiny, not sacred. They are man-made. And what is built by us can and must be dismantled by us. Let us do that together.

Tooba Tariq
Karachi

Inam Jaffar
Lahore

A good step

THE provincial government in Balochistan has announced fully funded scholarships for transgender students under the Balochistan Education Endowment Fund (BEEF). These scholarships will cover their complete educational journey, from nursery to graduation, ensuring 16 years of uninterrupted education. This is a wonderful step that deserves unqualified appreciation.

In addition to these scholarships, the government has also introduced free tuition classes, technical education programmes, information technology (IT) courses and recreational learning opportunities for transgender students. These initiatives are designed to enhance their skills and prepare them for leading a life marked by independence and respect.

The initial phase of the programme includes four to five months of foundation courses. During this time, students are provided training in fundamental academic knowledge, language proficiency, and other essential life skills.

Moreover, these courses are intended to bridge the educational gap, and equip transgender students with the confidence and competence needed to thrive in mainstream academic environment.

This initiative offers hope for a brighter future where transgender individuals would be able to contribute to society with dignity, talent and knowledge.

The provincial government's efforts

them. He does not help them. Instead, he asks for a CNIC; this acts as an insurance that the wheelchair would not be stolen.

If it were a visit to some Outpatient Department (OPD), all of this would have been fine, for, after all, such visits are not even remotely as critical as emergency visits are. In cases pertaining to cardiac care, especially myocardial infarctions, each second is important.

The interaction between the wheelchair staff and the attendant in the process of getting one's CNIC takes around 10-15 seconds. These are about 10-15 seconds too many. This time interval could be the window between life and death.

Besides, handing the most important personal document to a stranger (the staff member collecting CNICs was not wearing a hospital uniform) comes with security risks. Under what law is the hospital collecting CNICs? Who would be responsible if the CNICs are lost? Who would bear the brunt if a lost CNIC is used in an illegal activity?

If this is the state of affairs at a specialised hospital in the heart of the twin cities — one of them being the federal capital — it is not too hard to imagine the abysmally poor state of affairs at basic health units (BHUs) and rural health centres (RHCs).

Name withheld on request
Rawalpindi

RIC affairs

ON a recent visit to the Rawalpindi Institute of Cardiology (RIC), I noticed a sad state of affairs. First, there was no parking space near the Emergency Department (ED), and people had to seek the mercy of security guards to let them take their patients to the medical staff before parking their vehicles wherever the designated space was.

Besides, patients have to first take the stairs because the ED is on the first floor. Their attendants help them into hospital wheelchairs. As soon as patients get into a wheelchair, a staff member leaps towards

KP asks Centre to release over Rs71 billion net hydel profit

Page 8

CM aide alleges unfair disbursement of funds to provinces

By Manzoor Ali

PESHAWAR: The Khyber Pakhtunkhwa government has asked Water and Power Development Authority (Wapda) to make arrangements for release of Rs71.1 billion net hydel profit (NHP) to the province.

In a letter, dated September 1 and addressed to chairman of Wapda, KP finance department noted that the province received Rs3 billion on account of arrears of NHP for the last fiscal on August 18.

The letter pointed out that for the current fiscal, NHP payable to KP was calculated at Rs34.5 billion and accordingly the proportionate share for the month of July and August amounted to Rs5.762 billion, which was yet to be released by Wapda to the province.

Besides, it said that with regard to the arrears of previous financial

year 2024-25, out of Rs28.6 billion an amount of Rs6 billion was released to the province during the current fiscal, leaving an outstanding amount of Rs22.8 billion.

The finance department also said that an amount of Rs42.6 million was also payable to the province by Wapda/federal government on account of five per cent annual indexation for the period 2015-16 to 2024-25.

“Based on the estimated generation data provided by Wapda, the total NHP amount for the said period is also to be settled,” it added.

It has asked Wapda to make necessary arrangements for the release of these outstanding amounts at the earliest.

The adviser to chief minister on finance, Muzzammil Aslam, told *Dawn* that the federal government was unfair in NHP disbursement to provinces.

He said that in 2024-25, the federal government disbursed Rs34.58 billion to KP while it released Rs65 billion to Punjab.

“Interestingly, the federal government has provided extra Rs30 billion to Punjab in last quarter of

2024-25 silently supporting the most resourceful province of Pakistan,” said Mr Aslam. Besides, he said that it was urgently demanded to release the outstanding Rs71.7 billion to KP.

He said that Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif had promised Chief Minister Ali Amin Gandapur during the last meeting of Council of Common Interests (CCI) in May 2025 that next CCI would be called in July to resolve three decades long issue of NHP in the light of AGN Kazi methodology and Jahanzeb Committee formula. “However, so

far the prime minister office has failed to fulfil his promise,” he added.

The profit from generation of hydroelectricity, known as net hydel profits (NHP), is payable to those provinces where power plants are located, under the Article 161(2) of the Constitution.

The provincial government has also been asking the federal government to fund the power house component of Wapda development projects through PSDP instead of revenues coming from Wapda generation tariff.

Gandapur conditionally backs Kalabagh Dam's construction

Page 8

Says reservations of all stakeholders should be addressed before execution of such projects

By Mohammad Ashfaq

PESHAWAR: Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Chief Minister Ali Amin Gandapur on Monday insisted that the projects like Kalabagh Dam's construction were necessary for the sake of the future generation."

He, however, said that prior to the construction of the Kalabagh Dam, reservations of all stakeholders, including provinces, should be addressed.

"I'm neither politicising such projects nor can I damage Pakistan in the context of provincialism. I can't put the benefits of Pakistan behind," he told reporters here.

Mr Gandapur said keeping in view the provinces' rights over water and after the removal of their reservations to their satisfaction, projects like Kalabagh Dam should be executed to the benefit of Pakistan and future generations," he said.

Earlier, the chief minister said that rains, floods and landslides triggered by cloudbursts in Malakand and Hazara divisions had severely affected several districts, with Buner, Shangla, Swat, Battagram, Bajaur and Swabi being the worst-hit.

He said that the natural calamity had claimed 411 lives and left 132 injured, while 12 people were

still missing.

"More than 12,000 families have been affected by rains and floods," he said, according to an official statement.

According to official data, 571 houses were destroyed and 1,983 damaged by the calamity, which also damaged 1,996 shops, 413 roads, 72 bridges, 589 government buildings and 99 power feeders.

The chief minister said that a provincial government's helicopter engaged in relief operations crashed during those activities, claiming the lives of five crew members.

He said timely measures by the provincial government enabled rescue agencies and district administrations to save 6,700 lives, and that 2,500 Rescue 1122 personnel, 1,000 civil defence volunteers, three army units and five helicopters were deployed for the purpose.

"From August 15, immediate emergency was imposed in the affected districts where 176 rescue vehicles, including ambulances, fire trucks and boats, were rushed, while 200 heavy machinery units, medical camps and four mobile hospitals were also established. To date, cooked meals have been provided to 250,000 people, 140 trucks of non-food items distributed and 15 water filtration plants installed in the disaster-hit areas," he said.

Highlighting the provincial government's relief measures, Mr Gandapur said compensation for deaths had been doubled from Rs1 million to Rs2 million per victim, while the amount for the injured was raised from Rs250,000 to Rs500,000.

He said for destroyed houses, compensation was enhanced from Rs400,000 to Rs1 million, while it was increased from Rs100,000 to Rs300,000 for damaged houses. "For the first time, compensation of Rs500,000 per shop has also been fixed for destroyed businesses," he said.

Giving details of payments, the chief minister said that Rs704 million compensation had been disbursed to the families of 352 out of 411 deceased and Rs30 million to 60 out of 136 injured persons.

He also said Rs367 million had been released to owners of 367 destroyed houses, Rs328 million to owners of 1,094 damaged houses and Rs126 million to 253 shopkeepers out of 1,996 whose businesses were ruined by the disaster. Also, 8,000 families have been given Rs1,500 each under food stamps.

The chief minister said that compensation for the loss of livestock would also be provided after the compilation of data. He said that disbursement of all categories of compensation would be completed in the next couple of days.

On restoration work, the chief minister said that electric supply on all 99 affected power feeders had been restored, 376 out of 406 damaged roads reopened, 65 of 77 bridges repaired, and 234 of the 386 impacted water supply schemes fully or partially restored.

"The provincial government has already released Rs4 billion for relief and rehabilitation, while another Rs5 billion will be issued soon," he said.

Deluge in India may compound Punjab flood

Page 8

Continued from Page 1

minute-by-minute basis.”

On Monday, Punjab Information Minister Azma Bokhari said that various cities were on high alert for the next 24 to 48 hours, including Jhang, Sahiwal, Toba Tek Singh, Okara, Multan, Pakpattan, Bahawalnagar, Vehari and Bahawalpur.

Speaking at a press conference in Lahore, she said the water released by India had created 'extraordinary circumstances'. "To meet those circumstances, there were extraordinary preparations and readiness by Punjab's authorities, rescue teams, and civil defence in times of emergency," she added.

'Punjab's worst flood ever'

Addressing another press conference, PDMA Director General (DG) Irfan Ali Kathia said 41 people have lost their lives in the floods, while eight have been injured.

He warned that Punjab is facing the biggest flood in its history, with the ninth spell of the monsoon predicted to bring more rain over the next two days.

He added that no new flood surge had entered Head Marala, but after the rains, the water in Leh Nullah at Katariyyan has reached up to 19 feet.

Mr Kathia said that there is no threat to Trimmu Headworks and noted that water from the Chenab would enter Multan within the next 12 hours, where it would merge with floodwaters from the Ravi.

He warned that a breach may have to be made at Safura on Monday night due to the major surge at Sidhnai, with arrangements already completed. He said the breach will affect 14 villages and 17,000 acres.

He added that a flood surge of 600,000 to 650,000 cusecs was expected at Head Muhammad Wala on Tuesday (today). An important meeting regarding Head Muhammad Wala had already been held in Multan and key decisions taken. If breaching occurs there, 16 revenue estates (mouzas) will be affected.

The PDMA chief predicted that floodwaters would accumulate at Panjnad on September 5, though at lower levels than earlier estimates. He said water from the Sutlej

was currently moving towards Sulemanki and Head Islam.

He claimed that timely decisions had saved many lives. He said that Rescue 1122 was conducting the largest rescue operation in its history, with 3,100 villages and 2,900 revenue estates affected across Punjab.

So far, more than 2.4 million people have been affected, with over 900,000 people and 600,000 animals relocated to safe areas. Relief efforts include 390 camps and tent cities, while the Livestock Department is arranging fodder and feed for animals.

Mr Kathia also noted that India had only provided information regarding the Sutlej, with no details shared about any other river surges.

He further said that there is no longer any expectation of a major surge at Marala, however, rainwater will still come.

Earlier, Multan Commissioner Aamir Karim Khan said over 450,267 people and 468,284 livestock had been relocated to safer places.

He said that a flood surge of nearly 800,000 cusecs in the Chenab was expected to pass through Multan between Monday and Tuesday night.

A decision regarding possible breaching at Sher Shah and Head Muhammad Wala would be made based on the water situation.

Urban flooding alert

Meanwhile, PDMA on Monday issued alert about urban flooding in Lahore, Gujranwala, and Gujrat due to heavy rainfall expected in the next 72 hours.

According to an advisory, Lahore, Gujranwala, and Gujrat may face urban flooding in the next 72 hours as parts of Punjab are set to receive rainfall.

"A well-marked mon-

soon low is present over southwest Haryana and adjoining areas, while a strong trough of a westerly wave lies over the northern parts of the country."

It forecasted "widespread heavy to very heavy rainfall, along with torrential downpours, at scattered places over the upper catchments of the Sutlej, Beas (upstream of Ganda Singh Wala), Ravi, and Chenab rivers, along with their tributaries and nullahs, as well as in Lahore and Gujranwala divisions, from Sept 1 to 3."

In light of the situation, the PDMA warned of rising river flows, forecasting "very high" to "exceptionally high" floods in the Sutlej, Ravi, and Chenab. District authorities have been directed to take precautionary measures, prepare for urban flooding, and disseminate information among the public.

Dollarised returns for oil transport approved

ECC clears \$300m oil pipeline project with Azerbaijan amid ministries' concerns

By Khaleeq Kiani

ISLAMABAD: Despite strong reservations from the ministries of finance and power, the government has approved a dollar-based guaranteed return on the transportation of petroleum products through the 477-kilometre Machike-Thallian-Tarujabba White Oil Pipeline, estimated to cost \$300 million.

The project will be executed on a government-to-government basis by a joint venture comprising Azerbaijan's state-owned oil company SOCAR, Pakistan State Oil (PSO), and the Frontier Works Organisation (FWO). Positioned as a strategic investment from Azerbaijan, the project had long been advocated by the FWO using local resources.

At a recent meeting, the Economic Coordination Committee (ECC) of the Cabinet approved the terms and conditions proposed by the Petroleum Division to launch the project, citing its potential to enhance bilateral ties with Azerbaijan and attract future investment.

However, official documents reviewed by *Dawn* reveal that Power Minister Sardar Awaiz Leghari cautioned against offering guaranteed dollar returns. He noted that lessons should have been learned from the experience with Independent Power Producers (IPPs). He urged a detailed assessment of costs and internal rate of return (IRR) before proceeding.

SOCAR had conditioned its investment on a "ship-or-pay" model — similar to the "take-or-pay" model used in IPP agreements — requiring full payment for the pipeline's annual capacity of 7-8 million tonnes, regardless of actual throughput.

The Ministry of Finance also raised objections, warning that dollar-based returns should be linked strictly to foreign investment. It stressed that such returns should not apply if local financing is used. The ministry also recommended extending the payback period from four to seven years to mitigate the early-stage tariff impacts and called for more realistic assumptions regarding interest rates and the weighted average cost of capital (WACC).

Despite these concerns, the Petroleum Division argued that the proposed changes would render the project unattractive to investors. The ECC, siding with the Petroleum Division, overruled both ministries' objections, terming the pipeline a strategic opportunity that could unlock further foreign investment.

The FWO had initially proposed a 14.6pc IRR and a 25pc equity IRR. The Oil and Gas Regulatory Authority (Ogra) noted that the project's final cost would depend on the adopted financing and operational model. The ECC partially addressed concerns by deciding that dollarised returns would apply only if foreign investment is involved.

Currently, about 70pc of petroleum products in Pakistan are transported by road, 28pc through an existing pipeline from Karachi to Machike, and only 2pc by rail. The new pipeline aims to shift a greater share of oil transport to pipeline infrastructure, reducing costs and inefficiencies.

As part of the approved framework, Ogra will allow transportation tariffs to be denominated in US dollars and will declare the pipeline as the default mode of oil transport. Oil Marketing Companies will be required to commit to minimum annual pipeline volumes. Any shortfall will be adjusted through their existing Inland Freight Equalisation Margin (IFEM). If collective commitments fall below the threshold, the shortfall will be covered through the national IFEM mechanism.

The FWO has already submitted a revised tariff petition for the Machike-Thallian section, which Ogra has accepted. A separate petition for the Thallian-Tarujabba section is under review. Although Ogra has determined a provisional dollar-based tariff, the details remain confidential.

Oil sales up 7pc

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KARACHI: Pakistan's total oil sales rose to 1.3 million tonnes in August, marking a 7pc year-on-year (YoY) increase and a 6pc rise compared to July, according to data compiled by Topline Securities.

Cumulative oil sales for the first two months of FY26 (July-August) reached 2.523 million tonnes, reflecting a 5pc YoY increase.

Petrol (motor spirit) sales stood at 675,000 tonnes in August, up 8pc YoY and 10pc month-on-month (MoM). During July-August, petrol sales totalled 1.288m tonnes, up 6pc from 1.216m tonnes in the same period last year. Analysts attributed the increase to growing demand from the two/three-wheeler and passenger vehicle segments.

High-speed diesel (HSD) sales also posted double-digit growth, rising 14pc YoY in August to 522,000 tonnes from 456,000 tonnes a year earlier, and 2.6pc from 509,000 tonnes in July. Total diesel sales during July-August stood at 1.031m tonnes, up 12pc compared to 921,000 tonnes in the corresponding period of 2024.

In contrast, furnace oil (FO) consumption continued its steep decline. Sales dropped 71pc YoY to just 19,000 tonnes in August, down from 65,000 tonnes in August 2024. FO consumption in July was 15,000 tonnes. During the July-August period, FO sales plunged 76pc to 34,000 tonnes from 142,000 tonnes in the same period last year.

The sharp fall in furnace oil sales reflects the ongoing shift away from FO-based power generation as cleaner and more cost-effective fuels gain preference.—Staff Reporter

Flour prices climb as supply concerns mount

Page 9

Despite govt claims of adequate stocks, wholesale wheat rate hits Rs90/kg in Karachi

By Aamir Shafaat Khan

KARACHI: Wheat and flour prices have surged sharply in Karachi's wholesale market, raising fresh concerns about food inflation and market supply, despite government assurances of sufficient national stocks.

Wholesale wheat now sells for Rs90 per kg, up from Rs72 in mid-August and Rs62 in July. This increase has pushed the price of flour no. 2.5 to Rs97 per kg and fine flour to Rs103, compared with Rs81 and Rs85, respectively. In early August, these prices were Rs74 and Rs79 per kg.

Chakki flour varieties are now available at wholesale rates between Rs110 and Rs135 per kg, marking an average rise of Rs20 per kg. According to the Sensitive Price Index (SPI) for the week ending Aug 28, the price of a 10kg wheat

bag climbed to Rs794 from Rs640. Consequently, 20kg wheat flour bags now sell between Rs1,700 and Rs2,100, while one kg of fine flour is priced at Rs106 — up from Rs1,350–1,700 and Rs93, respectively, in early August.

With flour prices continuing to rise, a further burden on consumers is expected once roti and naan (bread) sellers adjust their prices to reflect higher input costs.

This surge comes despite a statement last week by National Food Security and Research Minister Rana Tanveer Hussain, who, while chairing the 8th Wheat Board meeting, claimed the country had 33.47 million tonnes of wheat against a requirement of 33.58m tonnes — a marginal shortfall of just 0.11m tonnes. He said the situation was under control and ruled out wheat imports, asserting that existing stocks were sufficient.

However, market stakeholders dispute the government's assessment. Chairman of the Karachi Wholesalers Grocers Association (KWGA), Rauf Ibrahim, said the claimed availability figure includes 400,000–500,000 tonnes from last year's leftover stock. He estimated the actual crop size at 29–30m tonnes this year, of which 3–4m tonnes have already been

diverted for livestock feed.

He questioned the disconnect between rising prices and the government's claim of ample stocks. He criticised the government's decision to suspend wheat procurement by flour mills and remove the support price under the IMF programme, saying it had created a free-market environment that benefits hoarders, speculators, and flour millers — but not consumers.

Rauf warned that the discontinuation of wheat procurement had left flour millers without official quotas, which previously helped stabilise the market. He added that farmers who sold wheat at Rs2,200 per 40kg are now at a loss, while flour millers continue to store grain in private silos.

With the next wheat crop due in March/April 2026, he urged the government to act urgently to curb hoarding and safeguard consumers, warning that flour prices could exceed Rs200 per kg in the coming months if left unchecked.

A flour miller echoed concerns about the stock data, claiming the total crop size this year is closer to 28m tonnes. He also feared that flooding in Punjab may have damaged some of the carryover stock being counted in the government's

total availability figures.

Asad Ali of Topline Securities said the recent wheat price rebound could incentivise farmers in the upcoming Rabi season. After facing depressed returns in the previous crop cycle, the recovery in prices may boost sowing sentiment.

Agricultural growth slowed to 0.6pc in FY25 from 6.4pc in FY24, as adverse weather, water shortages, and rising input costs undermined farm profitability. Major crop output fell 13.5pc year-on-year, with wheat production declining by 9pc. According to FFC estimates, farmers lost Rs10,695 per acre this year, compared with profits of Rs13,572 per acre last season.

SBP estimates an 11pc decline in wheat production for FY25 due to weak profitability, which discouraged sowing. Asad noted that although current wheat prices remain 43pc below the previous peak of Rs1,256 per 10kg, the latest price spike offers some relief to struggling farmers.

He added that the current rebound may help restore confidence in wheat cultivation, provided the government ensures better market regulation and protection for farmers.

Consumer price growth slows, but cost of living remains high

Page 9

Inflation in August fell to its lowest in over a year, but non-food and core inflation remains elevated

By Mubarak Zeb Khan

ISLAMABAD: Headline consumer inflation eased to 3 per cent in August slightly fell from 4.1pc a month earlier, driven by a slight decrease in food and energy prices, official data released by the Pakistan Bureau of Statistics (PBS) showed on Monday.

The slight reverse in the inflation rate from the previous uptick over the past two months is attributed to decline in petrol and diesel prices, and electricity charges. On a month-on-month basis, inflation declined by 0.6pc compared to the previous week.

The inflation between July and August was recorded at 3.53pc this year, the lowest compared to 10.36pc over the corresponding months of last year.

Despite the month-on-month increase, average annual inflation for FY25 dropped sharply to 4.49pc from 23.41pc in the previous year, aided by a high base effect, declining food prices, and lower transport costs.

Economists describe the current trend as disinflation — a slowdown in the pace of rising prices, not a general decrease as seen in deflation — though the cost of living remains high for many households.

Inflation had previously fallen into single digits in August 2024 — at 9.6pc — for the first time in over three years, continuing a declining trend until the recent rebound. The government has projected an inflation target of 7pc for the current fiscal year.

Food inflation in August decreased by 0.5pc in urban areas and 0.5pc in rural areas, while non-food inflation reached 5.9pc in urban areas and 5.2pc in rural regions. This marks that non-food inflation is still very high.

In August, core inflation — excluding volatile food and energy components — stood at 6.9pc in urban areas and 7.8pc in rural areas.

Urban food items that saw notable month-on-month price increases included tomatoes (19.63pc), onions (14.38pc), eggs (12.84pc), chicken (4.16pc), butter (3.21pc), fish (1.46pc), gur (0.79pc), rice (0.73pc), condiments and spices (0.64pc), meat (0.41pc), milk powder (0.34pc) and readymade food (0.26pc).

Conversely, declines were noted in fresh fruits (21.16pc), fresh vegetables (18.48pc), potatoes (8.77pc), sugar (5.49pc), pulse moong (2.81pc), gram whole (2.16pc), pulse gram (2.09pc), pulse mash (1.40pc), wheat products (1.31pc), wheat flour (1.24pc), pulse masoor (0.82pc) and besan (0.49pc).

Non-food categories also witnessed significant price hikes, including newspapers (11.93pc), hospitals services (1.71pc), education (1.61pc), cleaning & laundering (1.41pc) and doctor (MBBS) clinic fee (1.21pc). Decline was also seen in Liquified Hydrocarbons (7.30pc), electricity charges (6.87pc), motor fuel (1.51pc) and transport services (0.71pc).

Govt to raise Rs4.8tr

T-bills, bonds auction

By Shahid Iqbal

KARACHI: The government plans to borrow approximately Rs4.8 trillion through banks and capital markets during the September-November period to meet its financing needs, amid rising fiscal pressures and the economic impact of recent floods.

According to data released by the State Bank, the borrowing includes Rs2.875tr through Treasury Bills and Rs2tr through Pakistan Investment Bonds (PIBs). Of the PIB target, Rs1.2tr will be raised through fixed-rate bonds and Rs750bn via floating-rate instruments.

The T-bill auction schedule indicates the government aims to raise Rs900bn through 12-month bills and Rs750bn each from six- and three-month papers. An additional Rs475bn will be generated through one-month T-bills.

In addition to bank borrowing, the government has increasingly tapped the capital market. On August 17, it raised Rs119bn by auctioning one- to five-year sukuk through the PSX. Earlier, it raised Rs2tr through Sukuk and Rs1.4tr via PIBs at the PSX on December 5, 2024.

The borrowing spree highlights the country's fiscal challenges. Domestic debt reached Rs53.46tr in May 2025, up Rs7.34tr from Rs46.12tr a year earlier. Meanwhile, debt servicing in FY25 is estimated at Rs9tr — about half of the total federal budget.

Analysts warn that the situation may worsen following recent floods, which have severely damaged infrastructure and agriculture. "The government will need to borrow more as revenue collection is likely to weaken due to flood-related disruptions," said one analyst.

PTCL-Telenor merger further delayed

Page 9

CCP questions acquirer's financial capability, business ethics, and investment plans

By Kalbe Ali

ISLAMABAD: The planned merger of Telenor Pakistan with Pakistan Telecommunication Company Ltd (PTCL) has faced further delays as the Competition Commission of Pakistan (CCP) raised serious concerns over PTCL's business ethics, funding sources, and lack of transparency in key documents.

According to sources, the CCP has flagged PTCL's failure to submit the required documentation and demanded detailed clarification on its post-merger investment plans, particularly in light of the company's ongoing financial losses.

The commission has also questioned whether Etisalat (e&), the UAE-based parent company of PTCL and Ufone, intends to inject fresh equity to cover existing losses and fund future capital expenditures, including participation in the upcoming 5G spectrum auction.

In its communication, the CCP has asked PTCL to commit to binding investment obligations outlined in its earlier-submitted business plan. The company has been directed to disclose the sources of funding for the proposed capital outlays. The commission noted that both PTCL and Ufone are incurring significant losses and questioned how profita-

bility would be achieved post-merger. It also sought clarification on whether the merger would be financed through bank loans or equity injection.

Additionally, the CCP raised concerns about PTCL's business conduct, citing a lack of transparency in data related to international direct dialling (IDD) services. The Commission has asked for precise information on volumes and rates charged for different IDD destinations from 2022 to 2024, as well as detailed billing between PTCL and Ufone, and comparisons with other major telecom players such as Jazz, Zong, and Telenor.

In its review of PTCL's financial reports, the CCP highlighted discrepancies in several revenue streams listed under "Other Core Products" and "Other Retail/Wholesale" categories. These entries show substantial revenues without corresponding data on service volumes or rates.

Furthermore, the CCP noted the absence of crucial details regarding party transactions, transfer pricing, and access agreements. It stated that PTCL's responses lacked clarity and that several answers were generic or incomplete.

"PTCL has again not provided the exact information in these questions and has given generic statements instead of providing the exact data/information," the CCP noted in its official correspondence to PTCL.

The commission's growing scepticism about the merger stems from the absence of clear financial and operational strategies, raising questions about the viability of the deal and its impact on market competition.

PSX extends recovery drive despite flood warnings

Page 9

By Muhammad Kashif

KARACHI: Despite warnings of super floods in Sindh following devastating monsoon rains in Punjab and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa — bringing the rural economy to a halt, disrupting supply chains, and triggering a spike in perishable prices — the Pakistan Stock Exchange (PSX) extended its recovery for a second consecutive session on Monday.

The market defied macroeconomic pressures as investors engaged in selective buying, helping the benchmark KSE-100 index surge by 1,353.34 points, or 0.91 per cent, to close at 149,971.12, according to Topline Securities.

Market sentiment turned sharply positive after Pakistan's Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation for August came in at 3pc, down from 4.1pc in July — well below analysts' expectations. The surprise data revived optimism, spurring

PAKISTAN STOCK EXCHANGE

T H E T O P F I V E R S

G A I N E R S		L O S E R S		L E A D E R S*	
PIA Holding CoB	301.00	Unilever Foods	920.32	Bank of Punjab	97.69
Hoechst Pakistan	216.81	Nestle Pakistan	77.20	K-Electric	85.90
Reliance Cotton	38.11	Indus Motor	38.59	Pervez Ahmed	54.52
Supernet Tech	34.19	Highnoon Lab	28.40	Pak Elektron	47.54
Khyber Textile	33.75	Elahi Cotton	25.79	Fauji Cement	43.14

(Share values in rupees)

* Volume in millions of traded shares

ACTIVITY

Total listed	532
Active	480
Gainers	272
Losers	175

PARTICIPANTS

Foreign	▼ \$1.52n
Companies	▲ \$0.66n
Banks	▼ \$0.83n
Mutual Funds	▲ \$3.01n
Individuals	▼ \$0.45n

I N D I C A T O R S

	Monday	Previous	Change
KSE 100-SHARE INDEX (Points)	149,971.12	148,617.78	▲ 1,353.34
KSE 30-SHARE INDEX (Points)	45,655.03	45,247.79	▲ 407.24
MARKET CAPITAL (Rs billion)	17,800.728	17,655.775	▲ 144.952
TRADING VALUE (Rs billion)	48.849	52.305	▼ 3.455

buying across several sectors, particularly cement.

Heavyweights such as Fauji Cement Company Ltd, Lucky Cement, Cherat Cement, Maple Leaf Cement, and DG Khan Cement recorded notable

gains amid expectations of improved cement sales. Overall, the cement sector led the rally, driven by speculation around infrastructure development and water storage initiatives.

Top contributors to the

index included Lucky Cement, Oil and Gas Development Company Ltd, Fauji Cement, Bank Al-Habib, and National Bank of Pakistan, collectively adding 691 points. In contrast, losses in Fauji

Fertiliser, Systems Ltd, Packages Ltd, Bank Alfalah, and Highnoon Laboratories shaved off 242 points from the index. Market activity, however, remained subdued. Overall trading volume

declined by 11.85pc to 1.18bn shares, while the traded value fell 6.6pc to Rs48.8bn. The Bank of Punjab led the volume chart with 97.6m shares changing hands.

Ahsan Mehanti of Arif Habib Corporation said the bullish close was supported by positive inflation data and early external debt repayments by the government, which included Rs2.6tr in total payments. Expectations of increased spending on post-flood reconstruction also played a catalytic role in boosting investor confidence.

Ali Najib, Deputy Head of Trading at Arif Habib Ltd, noted that the new month opened on a strong footing, with the index carrying forward its upward momentum.

He highlighted the continued strength in cement stocks, many of which gained between 2.5pc and 7.5pc, driven by renewed discussions around infrastructure and water projects.

ACTIVITY

Total listed	532
Active	480
Gainers	272
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PARTICIPANTS

Foreign	▼ \$1.52m
Companies	▲ \$0.66m
Banks	▼ \$0.83m
Mutual Funds	▲ \$3.01m
Individuals	▼ \$0.45m

Derailment of polls will be 'dangerous', Yunus warns

Page 10

DHAKA: Bangladesh's leader has warned that any deviation from planned elections would be "extremely dangerous", as violent political rivalries deepen a year after the overthrow of prime minister Sheikh Hasina.

The warning comes after protests in the South Asian nation, which left a key leader hospitalised, with parties vying for power ahead of the first elections since the uprising.

Arguments between parties have escalated, including over who will be able to contest in the polls, scheduled for February, as well as the bid by interim leader Muhammad Yunus to push through a raft of democratic reforms.

"The chief adviser said there is no alternative to an election," Yunus' press secretary Shafiqul Alam said on Sunday. "Any deviation from it would be extremely dangerous for the country." Yunus, the 85-year-old Nobel Peace

Prize winner who has been leading the caretaker government as its chief adviser since the August 2024 uprising, held rounds of meetings with key parties.

He met on Monday with army chief General Waker-Uz-Zaman, who he thanked for the "continued contribution to the maintenance of law and order". Bangladesh has a long history of military coups and the army retains a powerful role.

Uz-Zaman, according to a government statement, said he backed the government, and "urged the chief adviser not to pay attention to rumours".

A key recent source of contention is whether the Jatiya Party, seen as a former ally of Hasina, should be allowed to take part in elections. On Friday, violent clashes erupted in Dhaka when the Gono Odhikar Parishad party held a rally demanding it be banned.—AFP

EU chief's plane hit by suspected GPS jamming

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BRUSSELS: A plane carrying EU chief Ursula von der Leyen was hit by GPS jamming as it readied to land in Bulgaria and Russia was suspected to be behind the incident, the European Commission said on Monday.

The commission said Bulgarian authorities believed Moscow was responsible for the incident on Sunday but it was not clear whether the aircraft was deliberately targeted as such attacks are common in the region.

"We can indeed confirm that there was GPS jamming," commission spokeswoman Arianna Podesta told a press conference.

The chartered flight landed safely at Plovdiv

International Airport, in the south of the country, without having to change route. Commission president Von der Leyen, 66, was in Bulgaria as part of a seven-country tour of "frontline" European Union states, which, sitting on the 27-nation bloc's eastern flank, are more exposed to Russian hybrid threats.

The region has experienced "a lot of such jamming and spoofing activities", a separate commission spokesperson said, adding it has sanctioned several companies believed to be involved. "The Bulgarian authorities suspect this blatant interference was carried out by Russia," Podesta said.—AFP



DEMONSTRATORS shout slogans during a protest in Bandung, West Java, demanding police reform and the dissolution of parliament.—AFP

Military deployed in Jakarta after protests

UN urges investigation over use of force

JAKARTA/GENEVA: Thousands rallied across Indonesia on Monday as the military was deployed in the capital after six people were killed in nationwide protests sparked by anger over lavish perks for lawmakers.

At least 500 protesters gathered outside the nation's parliament in Jakarta, watched by soldiers and police throughout the day, before dissipating after President Prabowo Subianto warned protests should end by sundown. But elsewhere protests were more volatile.

In Gorontalo city on Sulawesi island protesters clashed with police, who responded with tear gas and water cannon, according to a journalist. In Bandung on the main island Java, protesters hurled Molotov cocktails and firecrackers at the provincial council building.

Thousands more rallied in Palembang on Sumatra island and hundreds gathered separately in Banjarmasin on Borneo island, Yogyakarta on the main island of Java and Makassar on Sulawesi, according to journalists around the country.

"Our main goal is to reform the

parliament," protester and university student Nafta Keisya Kemalia, 20, said outside parliament before the protest ended. "Do they want to wait until we have a martial law?" The deadly protests, which began last week over MP housing allowances nearly 10 times the minimum wage in Jakarta, have forced President Prabowo Subianto and parliament leaders to make a U-turn over the perks.

Demonstrations began peacefully, but turned violent against the nation's elite paramilitary police unit after footage showed one of its teams running over 21-year-old delivery driver Affan Kurniawan late Thursday.

Protests have since spread from Jakarta to other major cities, in the worst unrest since Prabowo took power less than a year ago. Police set up checkpoints across the capital on Monday, while officers and the military conducted city-wide patrols and deployed snipers in key locations, while the usually traffic-clogged streets were quieter than usual. At least one group, the Alliance of Indonesian Women, said it had cancelled its planned protest because of heightened security.

Schools and universities in Jakarta were holding classes online until at least Tuesday, and

civil servants based in the city were asked to work from home.

On Monday Prabowo paid a visit to injured police at a hospital where he criticised protesters. "The law states that if you want to demonstrate, you must ask for permission, and permission must be granted, and it must end at 6:00 pm," he said.

UN urges probe

The United Nations on Monday called for investigations into alleged use of disproportionate force after six people were killed in protests across Indonesia sparked by anger over lawmakers' lavish perks.

"We are following closely the spate of violence in Indonesia in the context of nationwide protests over parliamentary allowances, austerity measures, and alleged use of unnecessary or disproportionate force by security forces," said UN human rights office spokeswoman Ravina Shamdasani.

"We stress the importance of dialogue to address the public's concerns," she said in a statement.

The UN rights office is calling for prompt, thorough and transparent investigations into "all alleged violations of international human rights law, including with respect to use of force", she said.—AFP

VOA hit by more layoffs as lawsuits persist

By Our Correspondent

WASHINGTON: After 83 years, the Voice of America (VOA) officially shut down its core operations this weekend.

On Tuesday, the first working day after the Labour Day long weekend, even the skeleton staff that had survived earlier rounds of layoffs will not report to work.

Kari Lake, the Trump-appointed CEO of the US Agency for Global Media (USAGM), announced the layoff — officially termed a “reduction in force (RIF)” — in a statement released Friday evening.

“We are conducting this RIF at the President’s direction to help reduce the federal bureaucracy, improve agency service, and save the American people more of their hard-earned money,” Lake wrote.

Founded in 1942, during World War II, VOA grew into the largest and oldest US international broadcaster. At its peak, it produced radio, television, and digital news in 48 languages, reaching a global weekly audience of more than 360 million people.

“VOA was more than just a media organization,” said a former employee who worked in one of its language services. “It gave millions access to reliable, fact-based news — often in countries where no such thing exists. I cannot understand why it had to be shut down.”

Several employees who spoke to Dawn on condition of anonymity said they had filed legal challenges against their dismissals and are barred from making public statements. One noted that most of those terminated were language specialists, many of whom face grim job prospects in the US media industry.

“And for many, it’s already late to learn new trades,” the former employee added.

Among those laid off were approximately 100 Pakistani journalists and staffers who worked for VOA’s Urdu and Pashto services. Others came from Vietnamese, Mandarin, Russian, Farsi, and dozens of other language departments that made VOA a key instrument of US public diplomacy during the Cold War and beyond.

The Trump administration began winding down VOA operations earlier this year. Nearly all staff were placed on administrative leave in March. About 600 contractors were terminated in May, and most remaining employees received termination notices in June. Some of those notices were briefly rescinded due to clerical errors, but USAGM made it clear that a permanent reduction in force was imminent.

Critics argue that the shutdown is motivated more by politics than by fiscal concerns.

“This is not about saving money,” said Patsy Widakuswara, VOA’s former White House bureau chief and one of several plaintiffs in an ongoing lawsuit against the administration. “It’s about silencing independent journalism that doesn’t conform to the administration’s worldview.”

A federal judge appeared to support parts of that argument last week. US District Judge Royce Lamberth blocked Lake’s attempt to remove VOA Director Michael Abramowitz, ruling that she lacked the legal authority to do so. Abramowitz had been placed on administrative leave after refusing a reassignment to a remote transmission facility in North Carolina.

The judge also ordered Lake and two of her top aides to testify under oath by mid-September, warning that continued non-compliance could lead to a contempt of court ruling.

Chinese cluster now world's top innovation hotspot, says UN

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GENEVA: Shenzhen-Hong Kong-Guangzhou has overtaken Tokyo-Yokohama to become the world's top cluster for innovation, the United Nations said on Monday.

The UN's World Intellectual Property Organisation (WIPO) said the Chinese cluster had leapfrogged its Japanese rival in its 2025 Global Innovation Index.

The change at the top of the world's 100 leading innovation clusters was down to WIPO broadening the criteria to include venture capital investments to formulate the annual rankings.

The UN agency dealing with patenting and innovation previously only used patent filing and scientific publishing data to identify local concentrations of world-leading

innovation activity.

"Venture capital investment activity helps capture how scientific and technological knowledge translates into start-up creation and, ultimately, new goods and services in the marketplace," WIPO said.

The agency said Shenzhen-Hong Kong-Guangzhou and Tokyo-Yokohama "make a massive contribution to global scientific publications and patenting outputs", together accounting for nearly one in five patent applications filed globally.

Indian cities surge

The new ranking showed that San Jose-San Francisco has now overtaken Beijing, Seoul and Shanghai-Suzhou to grab the

third place.

London has shot up from 21st to eighth place, while Bengaluru has likewise jumped from 56th place to 21st on the back of venture capital deals.

"Innovation clusters form the backbone of strong national innovation ecosystems, helping to anchor and strengthen the journey from ideas to market," said WIPO chief Daren Tang.

The recalibrated rankings "highlight which clusters are turning scientific research into economic results".

Overall, the change in methodology has seen East Asian clusters drop while US clusters have made gains. The change boosted Indian clusters, while those in the European

Union — where the venture capital markets are sometimes less vigorous than in the United States — have tended to see a decline.

Most innovation clusters

The top 100 innovation clusters are spread across 33 economies, uniting "top universities, researchers, inventors, venture capitalists and research and development firms in driving forward breakthrough ideas", WIPO said.

By country, China for the third consecutive year led the ranking with the most clusters in the top 100, at 24, followed by the United States with 22 clusters.

WIPO said the clusters with the most innovation-intensive activity in proportion

to population size were San Jose-San Francisco in the United States, followed by Britain's Cambridge.

Top 15

The top 15 innovation clusters in 2025: 1: Shenzhen-Hong Kong-Guangzhou (China) 2: Tokyo-Yokohama (Japan) 3: San Jose-San Francisco (United States) 4: Beijing (China) 5: Seoul (South Korea) 6: Shanghai-Suzhou (China) 7: New York City (United States) 8: London (Britain) 9: Boston-Cambridge (United States) 10: Los Angeles (United States) 11: Osaka-Kobe-Kyoto (Japan) 12: Paris (France) 13: Hangzhou (China) 14: San Diego (United States) 15: Nanjing (China).—AFP



ACTRESS Kim Novak receives the Golden Lion for Lifetime Achievement during the International Venice Film Festival.—AFP

Venice honours Hitchcock heroine Novak with lifetime achievement award

VENICE: The Venice Film Festival celebrated Hollywood actress Kim Novak on Monday, bestowing a lifetime achievement award to the reluctant star and platinum blonde heroine of Alfred Hitchcock's *Vertigo*, now 92.

Novak received a standing ovation and extended applause when handed her Golden Lion award from Mexican director Guillermo del Toro, ahead of the world premiere of the documentary *Kim Novak's Vertigo*, directed by Alexandre Philippe.

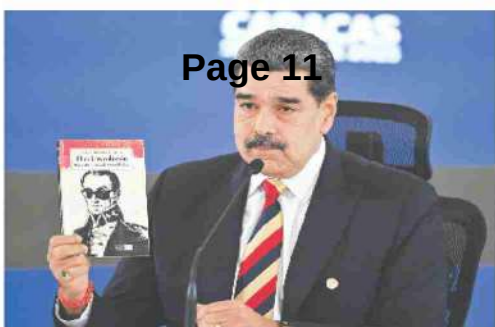
Wearing an emerald and black silk gown, the former screen siren who chose to defy the Hollywood studio system raised her arms in acknowledgement of the cheers, mouthing "thank you" to the audience.

"I'd like to thanks the gods up there in Heaven, all of them. Not one in particular. Just all of them," said Novak.

"They have given me such a gift but they they waited, they waited until it would be the most meaningful in my life, at the end of my lifetime to get this from you." Novak is best known for playing the chilling dual role of suicidal blonde Madeleine Elster and brunette shop girl Judy Barton in the 1958 Hitchcock classic *Vertigo*, playing opposite James Stewart.

But she had a short-lived career, refusing to accept the iron-fisted rule of studio executives and walking away from Hollywood less than a decade later to focus on painting.

Novak was "one of the most beloved icons of an entire era of Hollywood films... until her premature and voluntary exile from the gilded cage of Los Angeles" said the festival's artistic director, Alberto Barbera, in announcing the award in June.—AFP



VENEZUELAN President Nicolas Maduro holds a copy of the book, *He is the Revolution: Political biography of Simon Bolivar*, by Cuban author Sergio Vilaboy during a press conference in Caracas.—AFP

Eight US ships ‘with 1,200 missiles’ target Venezuela: Maduro

CARACAS: Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro claimed on Monday that eight US military vessels “with 1,200 missiles” were targeting his country, denouncing an “absolutely criminal, bloody threat.”

The United States, which accuses Maduro of leading a drug cartel, has announced a deployment of warships to the southern Caribbean in an anti-drug trafficking operation.

Maduro railed at a meeting with international media in Caracas on Monday against “the greatest threat that has been seen on our continent in the last 100 years” in the form of “eight military ships with 1,200 missiles and a submarine targeting Venezuela.”

The president, whose last two re-elections in 2024 and 2018 were not recognised by the United States or much of the international community, said that “in response to maximum military pressure, we have declared maximum readiness to defend Venezuela.” Washington has doubled the bounty for Maduro’s capture to \$50 million but has made no public threat to invade Venezuela.

Caracas has said it would patrol its territorial waters and mobilise more than four million militia members in response to the US “threats.” Maduro deplored that communications channels with the United States have broken down, and vowed his country “will never give in to blackmail nor threats of any kind.”

Maduro warned US President Donald Trump that his Secretary of State Marco Rubio wanted to “lead him into a bloodbath... with a massacre against the people of Venezuela.”—AFP

A chronology of frequent earthquakes in Pakistan and Afghanistan

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MORE than 800 people are dead and over 1,500 injured after an earthquake of magnitude 6 struck the rugged eastern region of Afghanistan, the region's latest instance of increased seismic activity.

Here are previous such disasters of recent years in the Afghanistan-Pakistan region which lies at the intersection of the Indian and Eurasian tectonic plates.

- A magnitude 5.6 quake hit Afghanistan's Hindu Kush region on Aug 27.

- A magnitude 5.2 earthquake hit Afghanistan's Hindu Kush region on Aug 19, at a depth of 186 km.

- A magnitude 5.5 earthquake struck central Pakistan on June 29, with its epicenter at a depth of 149 km.

- A magnitude 5.7 earthquake struck Pakistan on May 10, the European Mediterranean Seismological Centre said.

- Quakes of magnitude 5.6 and 5.8 hit the Hindu Kush and Afghanistan-Tajikistan border regions, on April 16 and 19,

respectively.

- A magnitude 5 earthquake struck Pakistan on April 12, at a depth of 39 km.

- Pakistan's southern port city of Karachi has been hit by several moderate or minor tremors in March and June.

2024

- A magnitude 5.5 earthquake hit the Hindu Kush region in Afghanistan on Oct 17.

- An earthquake of magnitude 5.75 struck Pakistan at a depth of 10km on Sept 11.

- Earthquakes of magnitude 5.5 and 5.8 struck Pakistan between March 19 and March 20.

- An earthquake of magnitude 5.5 hit northwestern Kashmir on Feb 19.

- A magnitude 6.3 earthquake hit the Hindu Kush region in Afghanistan on Jan 11.

- A magnitude 5 earthquake hit the Afghanistan-Tajikistan border region on Jan 5

2023

- An earthquake of magni-



INJURED Afghan children receive treatment at a hospital after an earthquake in Jalalabad.—AFP

- tude 5.3 hit the Afghanistan-Tajikistan border region on Nov 15.
- Many died as multiple earthquakes rattled Afghanistan in October.

- On August 6, an earthquake of magnitude 5.1 hit the Afghanistan-Tajikistan border.
- Earthquakes of magnitude

- 5.6 and 5.7 hit the Hindu Kush region in Afghanistan on May 3 and on Aug 5, respectively.

- An earthquake of magnitude 6.5 hit northern Afghanistan in late March, killing at least 13.

- A magnitude 5.8 earthquake hit the Hindu Kush region in

Afghanistan on Jan 5.

2022

- An earthquake of magnitude 4.3 hit southeastern Afghanistan on December 16.

- Over Sept 5 and 6, at least two earthquakes struck Afghanistan, with one killing at least eight.

- A magnitude 5.6 quake struck Pakistan's southwestern region on Aug 1.

- A magnitude 6 earthquake in Afghanistan killed more than 1,000 people in June.

- A magnitude 5.7 earthquake struck the Hindu Kush region in Afghanistan on Feb 5.

- An earthquake of magnitude 5.6, at a depth of 30km, hit western Afghanistan on Jan 17.

2021

- At least 15 people were killed after an earthquake struck southern Pakistan on Oct 7.

- A magnitude 4.6 earthquake, at a depth of 17.6 km, shook Afghanistan on May 19.—Reuters

UK, Japan, South Korea endure hottest summer on record

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LONDON: The UK, Japan and South Korea sweltered this year through the hottest summers since each country began keeping records, their weather agencies said on Monday.

Temperatures the world over have soared in recent years as human-induced climate change creates ever more erratic weather patterns. The UK's provisional mean June-August temperature was 16.1C, which was 1.51C above the long-term average and surpassed all years since 1884, including the previous record, set in 2018, the Met Office said.

The British summer saw four heatwaves, below-average rainfall and sustained sunshine, and followed the nation's warmest spring in more than a century.

Japan's average temperature spike was even starker over the same three summer months, at 2.36C above "the standard value", making it the hottest since records began in 1898, the Japan Meteorological Agency (JMA) said. It was the third consecutive summer of record high temperatures, the agency

noted.

This year's scorching heat left some 84,521 people hospitalised nationwide from May 1 to Aug 24, according to Japan's Fire and Disaster Management Agency.

In South Korea, the average June-August temperature was 25.7C, "the highest since data collection began in 1973", the Korea Meteorological Administration said in a press release. The previous record over the same period was 25.6C, set just last year.

'Very hot'

Britain — known for its damp and grey climate — struggled through the record hot summer, which poses a host of challenges for a country ill-equipped for such conditions.

Homes in the UK are designed to keep the heat in during the winter, and air conditioners are rare in homes and public places, such as much of London's sprawling underground "Tube" metro system.

"It's hard to spend a hot day (here),"

Ruidi Luan, a 26-year-old student from China, said in London during the August heatwave. "There's no air conditioner in our dorm. It is sometimes very hot, and especially in public transport." Drought was declared in five out of 14 regions in England, while the Environment Agency classed the water shortfall as "nationally significant", as farmers struggle with stunted harvests.

In Tokyo, Miyu Fujita, a 22-year-old businesswoman, said she had mostly socialised indoors this summer to escape the oppressive temperatures. "When I was a child, summer was the time to go outside and play," she said. "Can kids play outside now? I think it's impossible." Japan's beloved cherry trees are blooming earlier due to the warmer climate, or sometimes not fully blossoming because autumns and winters are not cold enough to trigger flowering, experts say.

The famous snow cap of Mount Fuji was absent for the longest recorded period last year, not appearing until early November, compared with the

average of early October.

National disaster

South Korea is meanwhile grappling with a prolonged drought that has hit the eastern coastal city of Gangneung. A state of national disaster has been declared in the city of 200,000 people, with water levels at the Obong reservoir, the city's main source of piped water, falling below 15 percent. The dry spell has forced authorities to implement water restrictions, including shutting off 75 percent of household meters.

Kim Hae-dong, professor of meteorological studies at Keimyung University, said the hot weather streak was linked to "the weakening of Arctic cold air due to global warming".

"Because it is expected to continue weakening with global warming in place, we forecast similar weather patterns to repeat next year," he said. Heatwaves are becoming more intense and frequent worldwide because of human-caused climate change, scientists say.—AFP

UK pauses refugee family reunion route

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LONDON: Britain's government announced on Monday it was suspending a scheme enabling families of refugees already in the UK to apply to join their relatives, as it tries to reduce irregular immigration.

Labour is struggling to stop record numbers of undocumented migrants arriving in the country by small boat, which is fuelling a bitter national debate and boosting support for the anti-immigrant Reform UK party.

Interior minister Yvette Cooper said she was "temporarily" suspending new applications to the so-called refugee family reunion route as she moves to reform the system.

"We do need to address the immediate pressures on local authorities and the risks from criminal gangs using family reunion as a pull factor to encourage more people onto dangerous boats," she added.

Home Office figures released earlier this month showed there were almost 21,000 refugee family reunion visas issued in the year to June 2025, the vast majority handed out to women and children.—AFP

Israeli-linked tanker comes under Houthi attack off S. Arabia

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LONDON: Yemen's Houthis said on Monday they launched a missile towards the Israeli-owned tanker Scarlet Ray near Saudi Arabia's Red Sea port city of Yanbu in a rare attack off the Saudi coast.

The Liberia-flagged vessel's Singapore-based manager, Eastern Pacific Shipping, owned by Israeli magnate Idan Ofer, said the chemical tanker was undamaged and under the command of its captain.

"We are aware of security reports alleging that our managed vessel Scarlet Ray was the target of a suspected Houthi attack," Eastern Pacific said in a statement on Monday, adding that all crew members were safe and accounted for.

Britain's maritime agency UKMTO said on Sunday it had received a report of an incident from a captain who witnessed "a splash in close proximity to their vessel from an unknown projectile and heard a loud bang" 40 nautical miles southwest of Yanbu.

UKMTO did not identify the party responsible, but said authorities were investigating. The Iran-aligned Houthis have launched multiple attacks on vessels in the Red Sea since 2023 that they deem to be linked with Israel in what they say is solidarity with Palestinians in Gaza.

Attacks near Saudi Arabia's Red Sea coast, which is further north,

have been rare in recent years. Any Houthi targeting of vessels along this coast will raise alarm as crucial energy exports are transported to global markets from Saudi terminals.

"While the projectile did not impact the vessel, the strike demonstrates a clear show of strength," said Ellie Shafik, head of intelligence with UK-based maritime risk management company Vanguard Tech.

"It is too early to determine whether this represents a broader strategy of escalation, or is a one-off response to the Israeli targeting of Houthi ministers.

However, Saudi Arabia is unlikely to tolerate repeated strikes occurring so close to its territory." The prime minister of Yemen's Houthi-run government and several other ministers were killed in an Israeli strike on the capital Sanaa, the head of the Houthi Supreme Political Council said on Saturday, in the first such attack to kill senior officials.

Saudi Arabia led a coalition that launched a military campaign in Yemen from early 2015 to support the Gulf-backed government against the Houthis, who had seized the capital Sanaa in 2014.

The coalition has in the past foiled attempted assaults using explosive-laden boats it says were launched by the Houthis.—Reuters

Afghan families from Pakistan let into Germany

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More than 2,000 Afghans were caught in limbo after Berlin froze its sanctuary scheme

HANOVER: After months of waiting in Pakistan until the recent German court rulings forced Berlin to offer them refuge, at least 10 families comprising 45 Afghans, who had fled the Taliban after they returned to power in 2021, arrived in Germany on Monday.

The 10 families have been among more than 2,000 registered Afghans caught in limbo in Pakistan after Germany's conservative-led government this year froze a

programme to offer them sanctuary.

They arrived in Hanover on a commercial flight from Istanbul around 2pm, said an AFP reporter and the Airbridge Kabul initiative set up to help those affected.

An interior ministry spokeswoman later confirmed that "45 Afghan nationals entered Germany. These are all individuals who obtained visas through legal proceedings... All of these individuals have fully completed the admission procedure and security screening."

Germany had set up a scheme to offer sanctuary to Afghans who had worked for German institutions or were otherwise deemed at high risk of persecution, including rights activists and journalists, after Taliban's return.

But the scheme was frozen under conservative Chancellor Friedrich Merz, who took office in May, as part of a wider crackdown on immigration.

As the Afghans had been left stranded in Pakistan, authorities stepped up a campaign to send those without residency back to their native country. Last month, Berlin said, more than 200 Afghans waiting to come to Germany were sent back to their Taliban-run homeland.

While alarm has grown about their fate, Germany has agreed to resume accepting "some of the others".

The German government said last week that Afghans for whom "courts have found that Germany is legally obliged to issue visas" would travel to Germany "in



AFGHANS who fled Taliban rule are welcomed by their families at an airport in northwestern Germany.—AFP

stages" once they had cleared security checks.

A spokeswoman for the Airbridge Kabul initiative Eva Beyer said the main applicants who arrived on Monday had been involved in

"politics, the justice system and journalism". Around 85 other stranded Afghans have begun legal proceedings against Germany, "and there are more every day", she said.—AFP

Israel is committing genocide in Gaza, says scholars' association

Israel sends tanks deeper into Gaza City; airstrikes claim 19 lives

THE HAGUE: The world's biggest academic association of genocide scholars has passed a resolution saying the legal criteria have been met to establish "Israel is committing genocide in Gaza", its president said.

Eighty-six per cent of those who voted among the 500-member International Association of Genocide Scholars (IAGS) backed the resolution declaring Israel's "policies and actions in Gaza" had met the legal definition set out in Article II of the 1948 UN convention on genocide.

Israel's military action in Gaza has killed 63,000 people, damaged or destroyed most buildings in the territory and forced nearly all its resi-

dents to flee their homes at least once. A global hunger monitor relied on by the United Nations says parts of the territory are now suffering a man-made famine.

The three-page resolution calls upon Israel to "immediately cease all acts that constitute genocide, war crimes and crimes against humanity against Palestinians in Gaza, including deliberate attacks against and killing of civilians including children; starvation; deprivation of humanitarian aid, water, fuel, and other items essential to the survival of the population; sexual and reproductive violence; and forced displacement of the population."

"This is a definitive statement from experts in the field of genocide studies that what is going on on the ground in Gaza is genocide," the association's president, Melanie O'Brien, a professor of international law at the University of Western Australia who

specialises in genocide, said.

"There is no justification for the commission of war crimes, crimes against humanity or genocide, not even self-defence," she added.

Convention explained

The UN Genocide Convention was adopted in 1948, three years after the end of World War II. It defines genocide as crimes committed "with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnical, racial or religious group, as such".

It requires all countries to act to prevent and stop genocide.

Since the genocide scholars' association was founded in 1994, it has passed nine resolutions recognising historic or ongoing episodes as genocides.

Ismail Al Thawabta, head of the Hamas-run Gaza government's media office, welcomed the resolution's "prestigious scholarly stance",

which he said "places a legal and moral obligation on the international community to take urgent action to stop the crime, protect civilians, and hold the leaders of the occupation accountable".

Several rights groups and some Israeli NGOs have already accused Israel of committing genocide.

Last week hundreds of UN staff at the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights Volker Turk wrote to ask him to explicitly describe the Gaza conflict as an unfolding genocide.

However, Israel continued to push tanks deeper into Gaza City and detonated explosives-laden vehicles in one suburb as airstrikes killed at least 19 people on Monday.

Residents said Israeli forces sent old armoured vehicles into the eastern parts of the overcrowded Sheikh Radwan neighbourhood, then blew them up remotely.—Agencies

Trump rebuffs India's 'zero tariff' offer as 'too late'

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said on Monday that India has offered to reduce its tariffs on US goods to zero, even as Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi was making public shows of solidarity with Chinese and Russian leaders in the face of trade pressure from Washington.

While calling the US relationship with India as "one sided", Trump announced the development on his Truth Social platform. "They have now offered to cut their Tariffs to nothing, but its getting late," Trump wrote. "They should have done so years ago."

The claim comes just a week after the US implemented duties as high as 50 per cent on many Indian imports as punishment for New Delhi's purchases of Russian oil, an action meant to pressure Moscow to end its war in Ukraine.

The Indian Embassy in Washington did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

The diplomatic friction serves as a backdrop to Modi's current visit to Tianjin, China, for a summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), where Chinese President Xi Jinping pressed his vision for a new global security and economic order that prioritises the "Global South," in a direct challenge to the US.

The US tariffs have strained the relationship between Washington and New Delhi, which had strengthened in recent years over shared concerns about China. India earlier criticised the levies as "unfair, unjustified and unreasonable."—Reuters

PIA to be privatised by November

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• Senate panel says four companies in race, two disqualified; Discos next in line • Senators seek clarity on energy supply, debt before privatisation

By Amin Ahmed

ISLAMABAD: A parliamentary committee was informed on Monday that Pakistan International Airlines Corporation Limited is expected to be privatised by November this year.

Briefing the Senate Standing Committee on Privatisation on the current status of the process, the Privatisation Commission secretary said that four companies were participating and would need to form consortiums with established airlines to operate PIA. Two applicants had already been disqualified for not meeting standards.

When Senator Zeeshan Khanzada raised concerns over PIA's Rs650 billion debt, committee chairman Senator Dr Afnan Ullah Khan suggested that the airline's two hotels could be sold to offset liabilities.

When Senator Khanzada ques-

tioned the government's strategy of selling profitable companies in the first phase, the Privatisation Commission secretary replied that investors are naturally more interested in profitable entities. Even if such companies were given away for free, he argued, it would still be the right decision as they may not remain profitable in the future.

The committee, chaired by Afnan Ullah Khan and attended by Senators Zeeshan Khanzada, Umer Farooq and Asad Qasim, also reviewed progress on other key privatisation initiatives, including power distribution companies (Discos), generation companies (Gencos), and Pakistan Minerals Development Corporation (PMDC).

The committee members stressed the need for clarity on energy supply agreements, debt restructuring and protection of profitable state assets before moving forward

with privatisation.

Power Division officials informed the committee that Nandipur and Guddu power plants are on the privatisation list. "Eight important issues of Nandipur have been resolved, with only one pending related to the gas purchase and sale agreement," they said, adding that the government was still deciding whether to provide a dedicated gas supply or continue with the current arrangement of supply on availability.

Regarding the Guddu power plant, the officials said that four of nine outstanding issues had been resolved, while disputes over land transfer remained. The plant's land is still registered under Wapda, though the latter has issued an NOC and the transfer process is underway.

Senator Afnan Ullah underlined the importance of resolving the energy supply issue for successful privatisation.



THERE is water as far as the eye can see in Kotli Loharan.—Dawn

GOOD DRAINAGE MAKES GOOD NEIGHBOURS

Residents on one side want culverts dismantled so floodwater can drain into the nullah, a proposal that has faced stiff opposition from those that dwell near the seasonal drain

By Khalid Hasnain in Kotli Loharan, Sialkot

FOOTPRINTS

THE poet Robert Frost believed that good fences make good neighbours. But for the residents of Kotli Loharan, a peri-urban community located on the outskirts of Sialkot, it is the lack of drainage — not fences — which has neighbours virtually at each other's throats.

The town's western side, through which the Khannay Wala Nullah flows, is slightly more elevated than the eastern side. The area has always been prone to flooding whenever the river overflows, but in the past, the water would find its course through the alleyways of the community in the form of rivulets and end up in the seasonal drain.

This time around, however, the sheer amount of water is staggering to behold, and it has not been able to find its natural path to drain into the nullah.

Make no mistake, both the eastern and western ends of Kotli Loharan are submerged; but while the water level to the east is around 6 feet, the west side is under half that depth.

Over the past five to six days, residents of the eastern side have struggled to dismantle culverts in a bid to divert the water west, so it can flow into the Khannay Wala Nullah.

This plan has faced stiff resistance from those who dwell on the other side, who have blocked efforts by locals and the district administration to make any cuts that would add to their watery woes.

This post-flood situation has created internal rifts, differences and given birth to water politics in the area — which is already reeling from outbreaks of disease brought on by the deep, stagnant waters — and curtailing cooperation with the government to deal with such situations.

"We have been cut off from Sialkot since Aug 26, as floodwaters are still present in our area, inside our homes," says Zafar Abbas Bukhari, a resident of the eastern side. "Many of our children and elderly people are ill and getting medicines from relief camps and other sources. But the issue is yet to be resolved," he tells us.

Another youth, Inam, narrates how he would ride into town on a tractor trolley to buy groceries, and then make the perilous journey back, just so his family could eat.

Mr Bukhari says officials had brought excavators to break down the culverts to allow the water to drain out the other side. But people from western side of Kotli Loharan had the work forcefully halted, arguing that their homes would be submerged under yet more water if this were to happen.

According to Deputy Commissioner Saba Asghar Ali, the issue in Kotli Loharan stems from the subdivision of agricultural land and the development on residential zones on it.

It has become common practice; first, structures are built illegally, then residents start demanding the construction of roads, sewage and other infrastructure, she deplored.

Massive flows

On Aug 26, a flood of around 400,000 cusecs hit Head Marala — near Sialkot — during the night. The flow increased rapidly to 917,525 cusecs, causing widespread flooding.

Although relief camps were reportedly made operational, many residents did not hear the announcements and remained in bed, leading to 22 fatalities in Sialkot city and Sambrial tehsil.

The devastating collapse of the Hanji bridge at Nullah Dek only compounded the area's problems.

Official data indicates that Sialkot tehsil was impacted by the overflowing of both nullahs, Dek and Palkhu, as they exceeded safe limits.

The damage so far include two collapse bridges, 46 culverts, 36 roads and 340,240 acres of cropland affected.

Unfortunately, Sialkot city and its suburbs still lack a modern drainage system, with domestic waste and storm water being pumped and disposed through the same sewage lines, laid decades ago.

The government also started a plan, implemented under the Punjab Intermediate Cities Improvement Investment Programme, with support from the Asian Development Bank some years ago, but it is yet to become operational due to various pending engineering issues, including the desilting of nullahs.